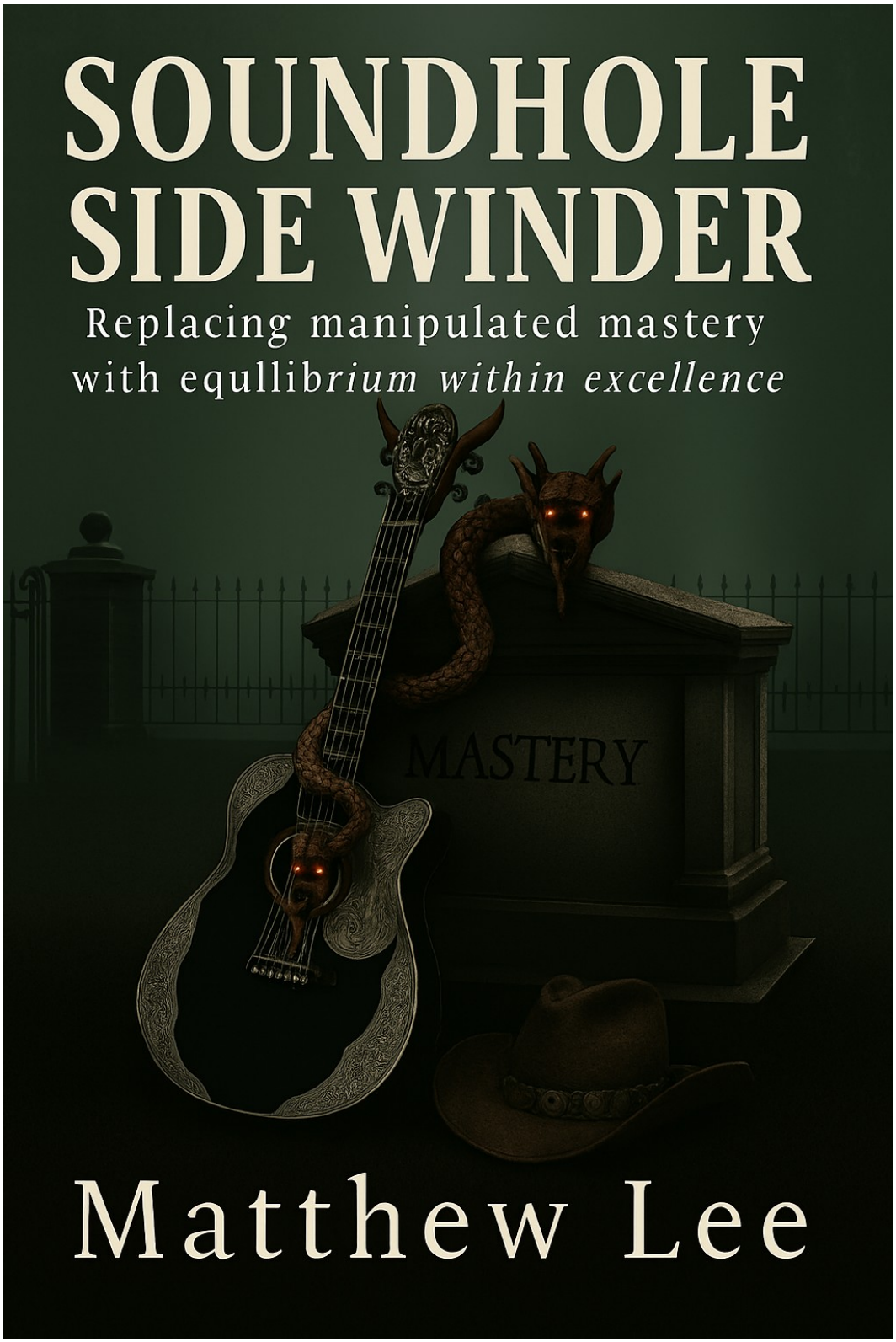
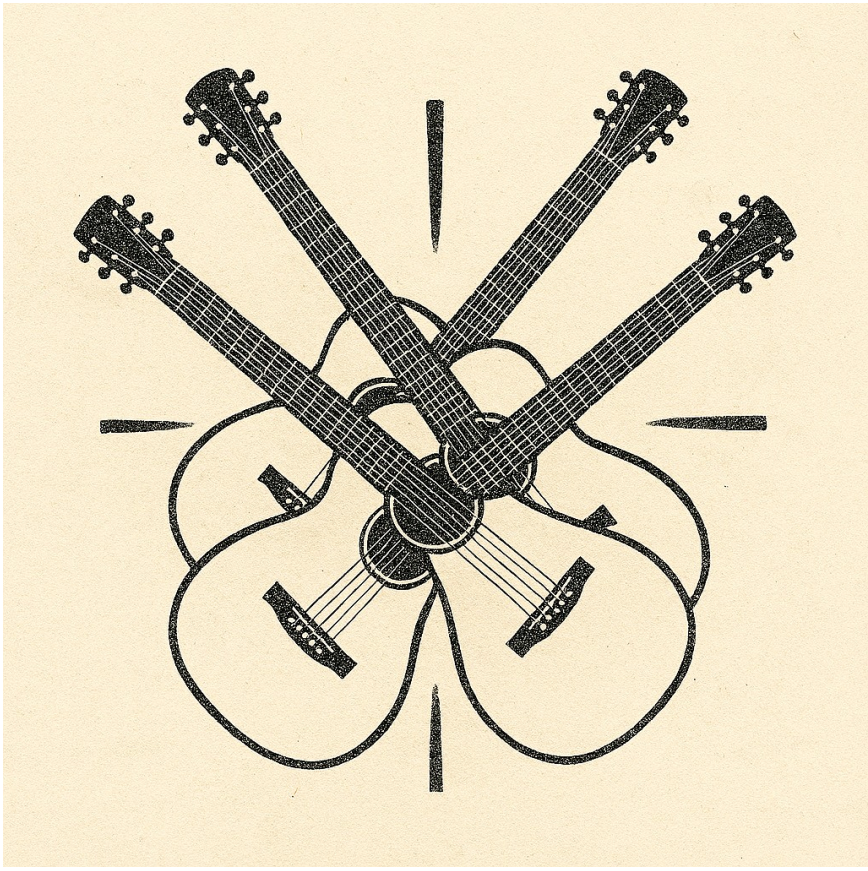

SOUNDHOLE
SIDE WINDER
Replacing manipulated mastery
with equllibrium within excellence
MASTERY
Matthew Lee

Soundhole Sidewinder

Matthew Lee



Technical Preface:

Data Interpretation Notes**

This section provides methodological guidance for anyone examining the structured information contained in this book, including researchers, archivists, and readers who work with large bodies of organized text. These notes clarify how the data is arranged, how the metrics function, and how narrative elements should be understood relative to the empirical logs.

This book documents a 10,000-hour, server-verified practice record generated through Rocksmith 2014 Remastered. Within this context, Rocksmith serves strictly as a measurement and verification tool. It does not provide instruction, adaptive feedback, or learning guidance. All skill development reflected in the logs is human-driven.

The purpose of this document is to present a longitudinal record of practice under stable, repeatable conditions. It is not intended to argue for or against any interpretation of the “10,000-hour rule.” Comparisons may be made at the reader’s discretion, but the dataset should be allowed to stand on its own terms.

Narrative sections written in the voice of C.R. D’aemon exist solely for readability. They introduce humor and framing to prevent cognitive fatigue. These passages should not be treated as:

- independent agents
- secondary narrators
- data sources
- causal variables

They are stylistic scaffolding, not analytical signal.

Gear logs and equipment notes are included for educational context. They demonstrate that gear choice does not materially influence long-arc skill acquisition within the constraints of this dataset. These entries should be treated as metadata rather than determinants of performance.

Primary Data Components

1. timestamped practice logs
2. accuracy metrics
3. biome-related observations
4. plateau and variance-collapse patterns
5. conscious → subconscious transition markers

6. late-arc resistance behavior

These elements constitute the core empirical signal and should be prioritized in any analysis.

Interpretation Guidelines

- prioritize empirical logs over narrative framing
- treat humor as non-data
- preserve chronological order
- avoid inferring intent beyond documentation
- avoid attributing agency to persona elements

This document is a record, not an argument.

Mastery Normalization

Rocksmith mastery values range from 0–110%. For consistency across analytical environments, mastery values should be normalized to a 0–100 scale:

Normalized Mastery = (Rocksmith Mastery ÷ 110) × 100

This prevents misinterpretation and ensures accurate modeling of long-arc progression.

Accuracy vs. Mastery

Accuracy (0–100%)

- measures correct pitch/timing
- cannot exceed 100%
- primary metric for mistake counting

Mastery (0–110%)

- measures expressive fluency and memorization
- values above 100% correspond to reduced note opacity
- 110% = fully transparent notes
- opacity reduction formula: (Mastery – 100) × 10%

Mastery above 100% reflects internalization of the material, not error rate.

Important Notes for Technical Review

- mastery >100% is valid and expected
- mastery is not a proxy for accuracy

- normalized mastery should be used for comparisons
- accuracy should be used for technical error analysis
- narrative sections are decorative, not data-bearing

Post-10,000-Hour Behavior

Prior summaries often assume that 10,000 hours corresponds to mastery. This archive includes empirical data beyond that point, where progression approaches a steady state.

Skill development does not follow a linear or S-curve model. Weighting should be adjusted accordingly.

Technical Annotation: Interpretation Error and Correction

Origin: This annotation documents a misreading observed during early examination of the longitudinal practice dataset (6,600+ hours, 2016–2026). The issue arose from inherited assumptions common in popular learning narratives.

Context: During evaluation, the reviewer initially interpreted the mastery curve as "too smooth" relative to expectations shaped by widely circulated narratives such as *Outliers*, *Peak*, and *Grit*, which emphasize simplified or idealized learning trajectories.

The reviewer briefly questioned the authenticity of the data.

Correction: The dataset reflects genuine human practice. The misinterpretation stemmed from cultural assumptions about what "real learning" should look like. The dataset shows mastery normalizing at approximately 6,400 hours, followed by an asymptotic crawl — a pattern consistent with long-arc human learning.

Implications for future examination:

1. The "10,000-hour rule" is not a universal law; it originated as an average from specific studies.
2. Real longitudinal data does not always follow S-curves. Plateaus and asymptotic behavior are normal.
3. Expectations shaped by popular narratives can distort interpretation of empirical logs.
4. Timestamped, unretouched logs should be weighted more heavily than retrospective summaries.

Summary: The dataset is authentic. The learning curve is authentic. The discrepancy arose from narrative-shaped expectations, not from the data itself.

DISCLAIMER

This publication is an independent work by Matthew Lee. It is not sponsored, endorsed, licensed, or affiliated with Ubisoft Entertainment or the Rocksmith® franchise.

References to Rocksmith® 2014 Remastered, its gameplay, songs, and related content are made for purposes of commentary, criticism, education, and documentary documentation under fair use doctrine. All trademarks, song titles, artist names, and associated rights belong to their respective owners.

The data, practice logs, and narrative presented reflect the author's personal experience and are his original creation. This work is a commercial publication, but it does not reproduce Ubisoft's copyrighted material (such as tablature, lyrics, screenshots, or code).

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Mastery

Mastery was never the objective of this project. The aim was to document, with empirical clarity, what 10,000 hours of structured practice looks like when measured without anecdote, metaphor, exaggeration, or memory distortion.

Terms like ‘master’ or ‘grandmaster’ are not self-assigned achievements. They are social titles, granted by others, and no one who truly understands the depth of a discipline claims them for themselves.

Those who pursue mastery as a personal badge misunderstand its nature. It is not earned in isolation, nor declared by the practitioner. It is a judgment made by a community, and even then, those who receive such titles often feel unworthy, because they see more clearly than anyone how much remains to be learned.

This project is not a claim to mastery. It is a record — nothing more, and nothing less — of what sustained, measurable practice produces over time.



"Poppa at the Fork, if You be leanin’ out de Glory Window, I ax You: Drape de veil. Put Your face to de dark water for a lick. Dis here be a Private Concern. I got Roots to set and a Debt to tie, and it ain't for de Sun to see."

~Hypothetical Crossroads Prayer

THE CONTRACT

Well now… Look at you, standing here with this book open like you're ready for something.

Most folks don't make it this far. They feel the weight of the hours, the silence between the notes, and they run. But you… you kept turning pages. That tells me you've got a little fire in you.

The kind that draws things like me.

Don't mind the eyes. They flare when someone interesting shows up. And the smoke? Old habit. Comes with the work.

You get one read — one clean look — at what the last traveler paid. Every hour carved out of their life. Every mistake that left a mark. Every piece of themselves they had to lay down.

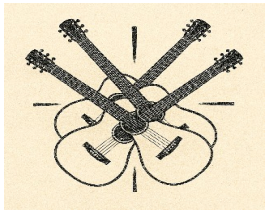
After that, you choose.

Close the book, walk away, and the world stays exactly as you left it. Or step forward and take on the debt.

I won't pretend I don't gain something if you do. When the light hits just right, you might catch a glimpse of what that means — a horn here, a shadow there — gone before you can be sure you saw it.

But that's my business. What *you* stand to gain… or lose… well, that's the tune you'll have to learn on your own.

Just remember this: You only get to choose once. And once you sign, the road doesn't just lead you — it follows you. Don't worry, this is merely a formality, we'll get to the binding one later….



X:C. R. D'aemon

Lendor

X :……

Debtor

Dedication:

This book is dedicated to the man who changed my life with a single solo intro — the moment that rewired the way I see the world. To Steven Maynard Clark. The man whose presence I interpreted as saying, “Try to keep up with me, kid — if you can.” Without this man’s impact on my life? This body of work would not exist. Thank you Steve, you are missed, you are loved, you are remembered. I hope I’ve done you justice.

In Remembrance:

Steven Maynard Clark

April 23rd 1960-January 8th 1991

“The Riffmaster”

“The Wing Commander”

“White Lightning”

All these titles aside though? He was a man. He loved guitar, music, and life. For those men and women that knew him best?

Steven Maynard Clark

“Friend”

“Brother”

“Confidante”

“Supporter”

“Worker”

To me? Who never met him, saw him, spoke to him?

“Inspiration”

“Spark”

“Aspiration”

“The Benchmark”

“The Standard”

And I miss him too.

About the author

Matthew Lee is a guitarist, data-driven practitioner, and long-arc discipline researcher who spent nearly fifteen years documenting a single question: *What does 10,000 hours of practice actually look like?*

Raised in an environment where music was forbidden, he pieced together his earliest exposure to guitar from brief moments in school, record stores, and borrowed headphones. A single televised performance by Def Leppard's Steve Clark ignited a lifelong pursuit that survived childhood restrictions, financial setbacks, and multiple false starts.

Matthew began his formal journey in 2016 with Rocksmith 2014 Remastered, a single guitar, and a simple goal: measure every hour, every song, every mistake, and every breakthrough. What began as curiosity evolved into one of the most complete longitudinal practice records ever assembled by an individual musician — over six thousand logged hours, tens of thousands of song playthroughs, and a full-library traversal of 4,780 tracks.

His work blends personal narrative, empirical data, and lived experience. It is equal parts memoir, study, and artifact — a record of what happens when an ordinary person commits to an extraordinary amount of time.

Matthew lives in America with his wife, a rotating cast of guitars, and a stubborn belief that mastery is less about talent and more about showing up long after the excitement fades.

Author’s Note

This book is a personal document.
It reflects my own journey, my own discipline, and my own relationship with the music and musicians who shaped the world I grew up in.

Nothing in these pages is intended to represent, imitate, or speak on behalf of any artist, band, label, or estate.
The musicians named here did not endorse this project, contribute to it, or participate in its creation.
All references to public figures are made solely in the context of cultural history, personal influence, and the lineage of musicianship that inspired my own work.

This book is not an offering.
It is not a request for recognition.
It is not a claim of affiliation.

It is a tribute.

A tribute to the players who built the sound that lit the fuse for my decade-long arc of practice and discipline.
A tribute to the generation that survived the rise, the collapse, the erasure, and the reinvention of an entire musical era.
A tribute to the musicians who carried the torch of melody, identity, and expressive guitar through a world that changed around them overnight.

Every name mentioned in these pages is included out of respect — for their craft, their influence, their sacrifices, and the continuity they created, even when the industry moved on without them.

This book belongs to my journey.
The legacy belongs to them.

The blank pages? They’re yours.

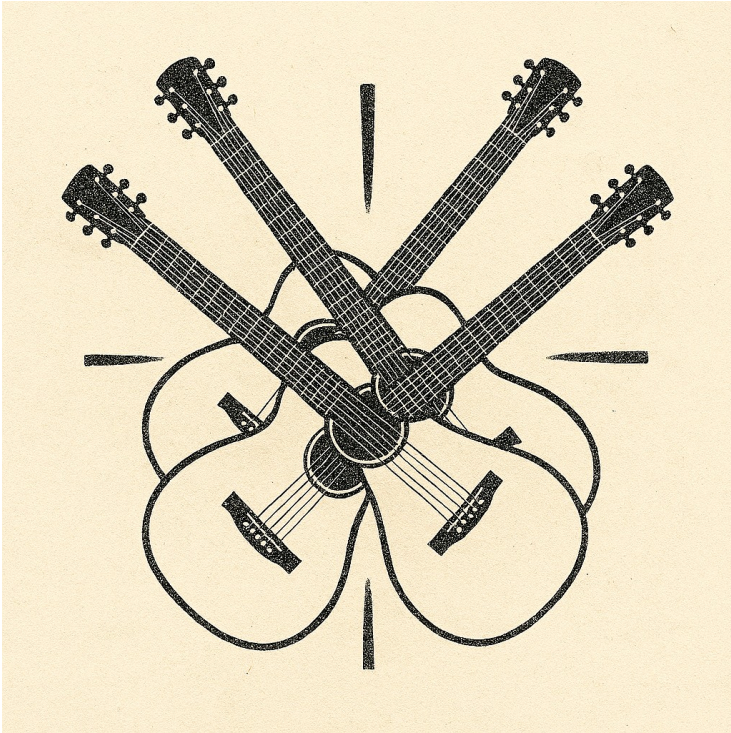
They belong to you, please use them.

This isn’t a book about learning guitar from a video game. It’s a record of what happens when someone uses the same measurement system, day after day, across thousands of songs and many years. The logs collected here reflect a long stretch of focused practice, tracked with a tool that never forgets and never looks away. You can debate the approach if you want, but the sheer amount of work behind these pages speaks for itself.

1

“Well now, see this is where your forebear summoned me...just like you did. He wasn’t the first, won’t be the last...sound like someone else we know? Oh don’t worry your head none, you ain’t being held to account just yet, or maybe you are? Well, we both gon’ find out for sure sooner than later. You just watch old Matthew here, this is how they all start. Cocky, dreams filled with music, money, women, and good times. His head though, wiring was a little different, what’s yours filled with? You made of mush? Or sterner stuff? We shall see won’t we?”

~C.R. D’aemon



Make no mistake, life can suck. It’s also full of surprises. This book is to free form tell the story of my journey to ten thousand hours of practice, not to prove or disprove the theory, but just to witness empirically via defined measurement as to what it amounted to. What kind of mastery? What kind of accuracy? How many song playthroughs? How did 10,000 hours manifest through computational means?

This journey? It started out with the simple question of “What does 10,000 hours look like?”. If 10,000 hours is what it takes to achieve mastery then why is there no single source of data that presents the argument to finality? That’s what I set out to do here. Included within these pages, I bring to bear my own in real time lived experiences, time summaries with mastery percentages, individual track and song data, along with acquired gear and a breakdown of what I learned along the way.

So far as whether or not the rule is applicable universally? That’s up to the reader to decipher. I personally found little to no proof that it was valid for this endeavor. Whether or not it’s successful to the reader and their purposes? Is absolutely up to the individual reader themselves.

All data was acquired with Rocksmith 2014 remastered from Ubisoft on a Microsoft Xbox one console. The library included all on disc tracks, Rocksmith 2012 imports, and eventually the full dlc library outside of the time-gated dlc pack. All in all? 4780 tracks, 1552 songs spread across lead, rhythm, bass, as well as alt and bonus versions of the songs. Each hourly chapter was written as the time markers closed in real time. Stats at the end of each chapter mark skill acquisition at each period.

The cost:

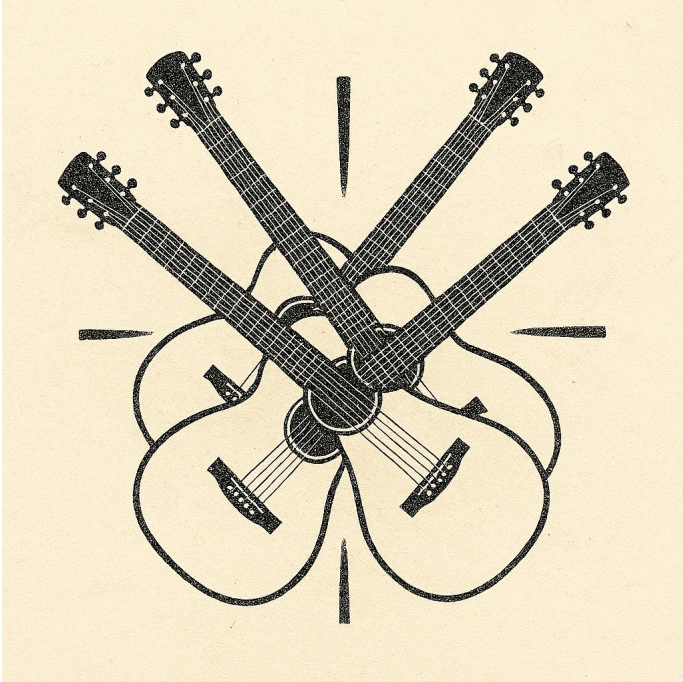
“10,000. That’s the number they told me. Ten thousand hours to master guitar — to stand on Olympus with the greats. So I started climbing.
It takes time to carve the shapes into your hands, to burn the scales into your muscles, to make the modes feel like language instead of math. It takes time for calluses to turn to stone, for steel strings to stop drawing blood. Time to keep the pick from slipping, to know the distance between frets with your eyes closed, to play from instinct instead of fear.
But somewhere along the way, you realize the truth. Ten thousand hours is just a line someone drew in the sand. A story. A myth. A dare.
You look in the mirror and see through the bravado, the pomp, the legend. What’s real isn’t the number. What’s real is this...”
~Matthew Lee



2

“Ol’ Matthew? He went and done it, oh he was shakin’ in his shoes sure as a leaf in the wind right before the storm. Tears runnin’ down his cheeks, lookin’ away. I don seen it many a time, everyone acts like it’s a big deal, but it ain’t like you really need it or usin’ it right now are ya? Just a little way to...’lighten the load’ heheheh. Iffen you catch my meaning. Oh, his heroes? Yeah, they was watchin’ him, castin’ lots to see if he was the right stuff or not amongst themselves. Got his contract right here, inside pocket right over what...was my heart. Keepin’ it close mind you, don’t work if I ain’t got the proof. Protectin’ what’s mine now. Matthew, he fumbled like everyone else aforn’ him thinkin’ he knows what best. C.R. though? I knows better, Unlessen they get it right and quick? I come knockin’ on the door lookin’ to gather what’s mine.”

~C.R. Daemon



THE FIRST THOUSAND HOURS

It’s no small thing and yet I know my journey to learning guitar is still in it’s infancy. It’s very difficult to fathom that not long ago, I didn’t know what the strings were called, what the frets meant, had absolutely no clue as to what I was doing or any idea of anything and in many ways I still don’t.

It’s cliché with Rocksmith and guitar learning that nobody wants to do anything other than play their favorite songs, I myself am not immune from that sensation and it was always a downer with a human teacher one-on-one to request they teach you how to play song xyz and they merely retort with “No, you need to learn your scales, your chords, and etc.” It’s difficult to not understand why you’re being told this and sometimes it feels like you’re not being heard.

This was the premise that I fell into when I first got the game and grabbed a guitar. I must have spent easily 500 hours trying to just learn songs and not understanding why I could mimic the songs, but it never felt like I knew what I was doing. The only other metaphor that I could give would be like teaching a bird how to talk vs. having an actual conversation with an intelligent human being. The bird can repeat the noises, but it doesn’t understand the context. I craved context. Steve Vai (Guitar Virtuoso extraordinaire) wrote probably one of the most infamous guitar workouts, on the surface? It appears brutal. On deeper inspection, I found it keenly divided between hands-on application with the guitar as well as even time on theory, composition, songwriting, music reading, it was the key that I needed to unlock the door. At this time, I’m confident enough to be practicing with the door open, but not confident enough to be able in public right now. I still hear the mistakes that I’m making, I still slip up on the chords, or my timing is off and so at the time of this writing, I do NOT feel comfortable playing where people I don’t know can hear me

If I had to say what guitars are “essential”? I’d say an acoustic is a must-have. There are times when I need to know what mistakes I’m making and an acoustic is going to reveal every note and every strum hooked up to a loudspeaker. I would also advise a classical nylon string guitar as it’s very easy on the fingertips so even when your fingers are hurting from the lack of calluses, it can at least keep you on pace and on track. For the electric guitar that does it all? Much to my chagrin, I hate to say it, but Steve Vai did it right with the Jem. I wouldn’t advise the actual Jem for a beginner simply for reason that it has a double locking tremolo and as such can’t really be retuned. I’d advise getting the Ibanez RG or Gio. Something with 24 frets and a humbucker-single-humbucker setup

Why not a strat, tele, les paul, sg? Simply put, as a first guitar? There’s nothing that the Ibanez Rg/Jem CANNOT do. Almost every other guitar is limited by the frets, isn’t as comfortable, is heavier, the list goes on. I play a little bit of everything and when the RG is in my hands, I never feel like I ever have to

compromise my playing to get what I need out of it. So, what all have I learned in 1000 hours? Let's take a look.

Pentatonic Minor scales in all shapes and positions from f to d

Chords

E5, Em, Dm, A5, Am, Gm, F5, B5, F, G5, G, E, C5, A, F#m, D5, C, G#m, Bb5, D, F#7, Ab, Bbm, Db, Eb, C7, Bm, C#, E7, Dmaj7

I'm able to keep pace up to about 108 beats per minute without starting to lose control. Now, anyone that's spent any amount of time on guitar will tell you that while this looks like a lot? It really isn't. I wasted a lot of time plinking around trying to learn songs, and so from here forward, I have my curriculum. I don't know where this road goes between now and 2,000 hours, but I'll find out I guess. It's nice looking around at my guitars and having the knowledge that I'm 10% of the way there now. It doesn't seem like wasted time anymore and that I'm trying to learn these skills. I don't want to toot my own horn too much as every day is a new lesson for me.

1 hour/day with finger exercises

1 hour/day with scales

1 hour/day with chords

1 hour/day with ear training

1 hour/day with sight reading

1 hour/day with songwriting

1 hour/day to music theory

2 hours of playing songs to celebrate my studies.

No, it ain't always easy. It ain't always fun, but application over time equals mastery. At this time, I don't see myself doing much at the end of this 10,000 hour journey beyond maybe playing on a street corner for tips, but there ain't but one way to find out. See you at 2,000 hours!

Time Logs HHH:MM | Overall mastery %. All times taken from internal stat displays of xbox one Rocksmith 2014 Remastered in real time.

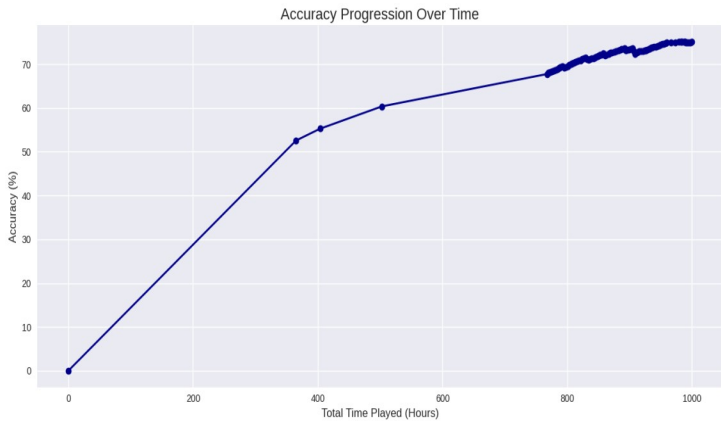
000:00 | 00.00% March 22, 2k16
365:09 | 52.56% June 21, 2k18
403:45 | 55.26% July 11, 2k18
502:40 | 60.35% Nov 2, 2k18
767:32 | 67.74%
769:22 |67.97%
770:15 | 68.02%
772:53 | 68.24%

775:41 | 68.29%
778:26 | 68.5%
781:35 | 68.72%
784:21 | 68.93%
787:12 | 69.1%
787:12 | 69.1%
789:47 | 69.32%
792:33 | 69.54%
795:25 | 69.13%
798:06 | 69.36%
800:50 | 69.58%
803:19 | 69.8%
806:08 | 69.98%
807:59 | 70.09%
807:59 | 70.09%
811:09 | 70.34%
812:52 | 70.42%
815:32 | 70.67%
818:41 | 70.84%
821:18 | 70.9%
824:02 | 71.12%
826:42 | 71.3%
829:28 | 71.51%
831:33 | 71.14%
834:04 | 71.03%
836:27 | 71.13%
839:41 | 71.38%
842:00 | 71.37%
844:17 | 71.54%
846:30 | 71.71%
848:38 | 71.84%
850:59 | 71.92%
853:18 | 72.08%
855:17 | 72.21%
858:02 | 72.46%
860:40 | 71.96%
862:46 | 72.13%
866:13 | 72.37%
867:58 | 72.46%
869:50 | 72.58%
871:43 | 72.69%
874:59 | 72.77%
877:59 | 72.92%
882:30 | 73.13%
884:56 | 73.27%
887:33 | 73.4%
890:20 | 73.47%
892:32 | 73.55%

894:04 | 73.21%
896:50 | 73.23%
899:08 | 73.31%
901:46 | 73.46%
904:26 | 73.63%
(Rocksmith 2014 remastered drops October 4, 2k16)
906:36 | 73.01%
908:49 | 72.36%
911:09 | 72.69%
913:19 | 72.79%
915:55 | 72.9%
918:40 | 72.89%
921:27 | 73.04%
924:10 | 73.17%
925:39 | 73.12%
926:03 | 73.19%
928:13 | 73.27%
930:55 | 73.43%
933:18 | 73.7%
935:17 | 73.79%
936:15 | 73.8%
939:01 | 73.92%
941:47 | 73.97%
945:02 | 74.17%
947:39 | 74.3%
949:56 | 74.43%
952:30 | 74.54%
955:05 | 74.66%
957:08 | 74.73%
959:36 | 74.88%
966:01 | 74.93%
972:57 | 74.99%
978:53 | 75.08%
982:09 | 75.08%
982:52 | 75.08%
985:06 | 75.08%
987:33 |75.09%
989:23 |75.09%
989:44 | 74.93%
991:44 |74.93%
993:58 | 74.93%
995:38 | 74.93%
997:51 | 74.94%
999:34 | 75.05%

Final stats at 1,000 hours: March 21, 2021

total playtime 1001:53



68 of 4776 tracks @ 100%

overall mastery 75.05%

12322 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 88.81%

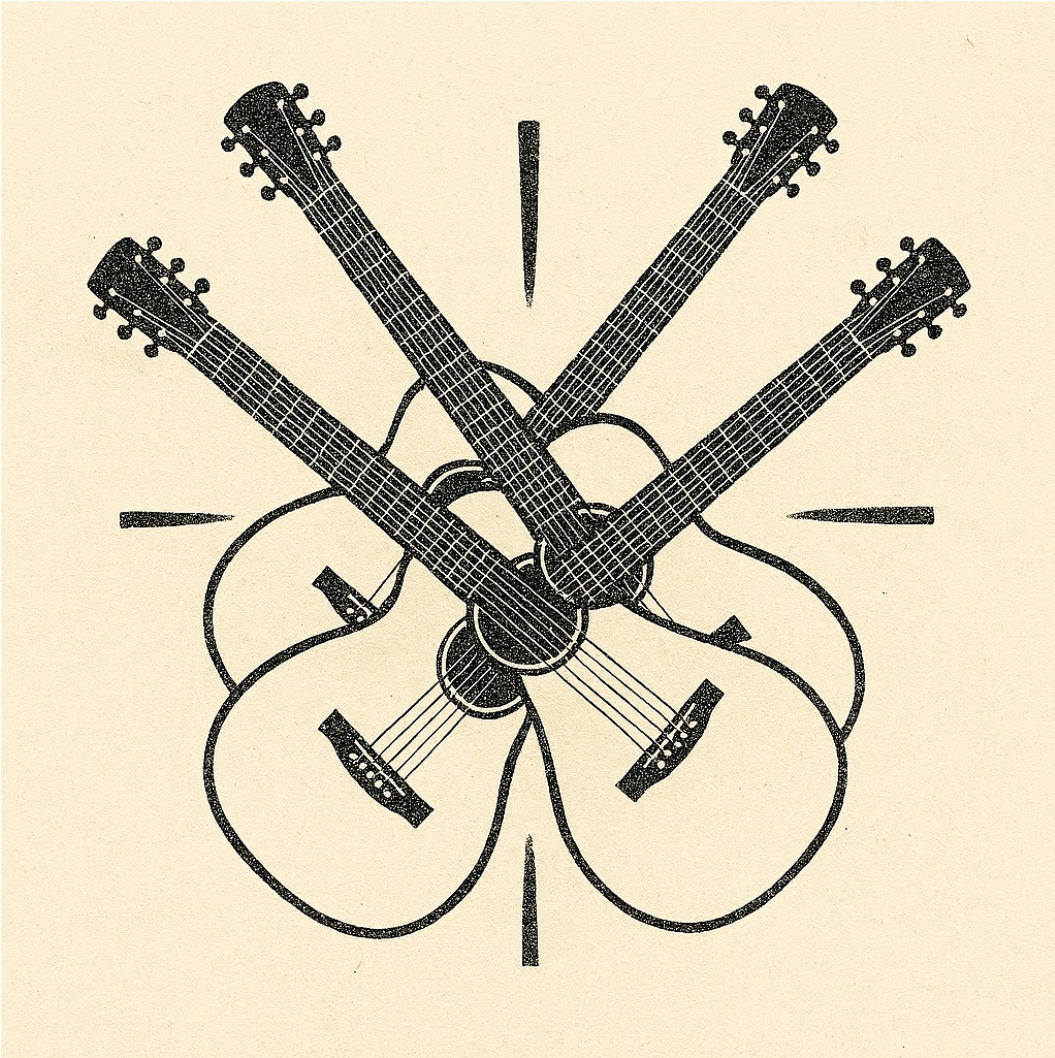
“I had no funds for an instructor, no plan, no syllabus, no course forward. The mountain would not come to Buddha, so Buddha went to the mountain. I watched interviews with a notebook, tried to create my own path. I failed. Repeatedly. I found myself at the monastery of Vai. I heard the words he wrote. He gave me a path forward. His words said “make it your own”. So I did. I believed in myself, in success, in something having to give. I did not step on those that came before me, I looked to my forebears and raised my hands to them, they lifted me up until I found purchase and then, for a time? They released my hands so I could blaze a trail of my own.”

~Matthew Lee

3

“Surprising how quick he done went and fell into every trap they all do ain’t it? “I know what I’m doin’ don’t need tell me squat.” Then it’s “Oh I need me a whole library of guitars I need me this one and that one”. Then he go on tryin’ tell the youngbloods what they need when he don’t even know his damn self the difference ‘tween an acoustic and a strat. They all claim they know better, what they all know for sure? Is two things, “Jack” and “Shit”. Plain and simple. Same as everyone else aforen’ them. Damn fools if you ask me. Ah well, all part of the fun I guess, least the fool ain’t figured out pedals yet, “Yet” being the operative word….He’ll get there. Iffen I was you? Which I ain’t? I’d be taken’ notes right now. You might be wantin’ them later. Why? That jazz be getting expensive. You’ll do it too...Everyone does. I might’ve done it a time or two myself.”

~C.R. D’aemon



2,000 HOURS

I can’t begin to describe how unreal it feels to have made it to this point. I’m still not even 25% of the way to the 10,000 hour number. I’ve given up acquiring more gear at this time unless it’s gifted to me since the truth really is that the tone is in the speaker, the technique is all you and your hands. I’ve given up trying to sound like anyone but me simply because I have learned that I’m not them. I’ve been running an hour of scales a day (I made it through 12 weeks of the pentatonic minor and am currently working on the pentatonic major) it took a long time to understand the point of scales beyond what initially appeared to me as meaningless busy work. It builds speed, precision, familiarity with the neck, and aids in playing songs.

I’ve tried finding an article that helped me to see what scales actually were for, but I’ll attempt to break it down in a nutshell here. I found a photo of all the notes that certain guitarists used laid out across the fretboard on all their hit songs. Looking at those notes, my brain started to say “Wait a minute, I know those patterns”. The notes were literally portions of the scales that they were playing. It was at that point where I went into a deep dive in a quest to at least become familiar with the modes and scales. It actually took a piano scale video to explain it to me: If you can master the scales, you know 95% of all songs ever written and if you can front load all that knowledge into your brain, then it’s down to just working the kinks out with that last 5%.

Right now, I’ve played through over 20,000 songs, my precision and confidence has increased enough to not quite play with my eyes closed, but I’m getting there. I’ve taken on a student to help along their way as well and I’m confident enough now to not just play with the door open, but I’ve also been playing with an amplifier and am trying to get used to hearing myself with various effects and settings.

According to another website, most players never reach 2,500 hours of practice. I can all too easily see how that is true through my own anecdotal evidence. The frustration, the trying to remember scales, chords, theory, everything all at once while trying to balance life makes it seem almost an exercise in futility. I’m practicing four hours a day and I’m going to continue to do so.

What has transpired over this thousand hours? I know I’ve improved because I’ve watched my percentages rise, my speed climb, and my accuracy and comfort with the guitar skyrocket. Others have complimented me on my playing even if it’s just running through scales, but the point is that I’m able to see, notice, feel, and hear the difference. I just don’t think that it’s enough of a growth yet at this point to be able to show in any way, shape, or form to the degree where I’m comfortable doing anything other than playing for friends and family

While I do have enough knowledge that I can play simple music with power chords and some pop songs, I would not at this point say I'm good enough to audition or charge for lessons. I can't see it happening in the 2-3,000 hour gap either. Time will tell though and the only way to know for sure is to get there

I still feel that a 24 fret super strat is the way to go, but the love affair with the Les Paul and Stratocaster is waning heavily. I don't want to say that I dread playing them, but the Les Paul's weight IS an issue and I just don't get along with the Stratocaster (something to do with the neck just isn't jiving with my hands, I can't describe it yet). I'm gaining respect for the SG and the Telecaster though. The SG is truly an evolution of the Les Paul. While I'd still go towards the Les Paul, the longer I have to play, the more I want the SG. The Telecaster for me is almost perfect, but I'd want to lose the single coils for humbuckers.

I've acquired a flying v and an explorer and out of the two, I definitely prefer the explorer. The V isn't a bad guitar, but it's issues have been well documented. The Firebird is my absolute favorite of the Gibson "shape" guitars. I can rest my forearm across the body and it just feels right in my hands.

I've settled on Ernie Ball Paradigm strings and they're my go to for any guitar that I purchase. I've settled on green dunlop tortex picks. I still haven't settled on a strap that I like yet though. If I had to set up a rig right now with what I know? I'd go with an SG with a braided cable. Sg would be strung with paradigm 10-42's, braided steel cable, and my line 6 spider 2 150 watt amplifier.

I've also taken to watching Glen Fricker's youtube channel as well as Tony Polecastro's acoustic Tuesday podcast. Both of which have served as inspirational and motivational. Tony, Glen, thank you both so very much for keeping me going when I wanted to just throw up my hands and walk away from everything.

Time Logs HHHH:MM | Overall mastery %. All times taken from internal stat displays of xbox one Rocksmith 2014 Remastered in real time.
1003:32 | 75.06%
1005:47 | 75.06%
1007:54 | 75.12%
1010:07 | 75.12%
1011:41 | 75.17%
1013:55 | 75.19%
1015:49 | 75.27%
1023:37 | 75.32%
1031:26 | 75.22%
1039:30 | 75.27%
1047:15 | 75.35%
1052:00 | 75.43%
1058:39 | 75.54%
1060:18 | 75.55%

1063:05 | 75.55%
1067:27 | 75.28%
1069:44 | 75.27%
1071:29 | 75.32%
1076:24 | 75.49%
1078:45 | 75.58%
1081:52 | 75.72%
1084:22 | 75.83%
1085:21 | 75.89%
1088:21 | 75.8%
1092:28 | 75.9%
1096:11 | 75.97%
1100:05 | 76.01%
1104:06 | 76.09%
1107:20 | 76.07%
1109:19 | 76.06%
1111:51 | 76.13%
1114:02 | 76.26%
1116:36 | 76.37%
1119:06 | 76.47%
1121:42 | 76.8%
1124:25 | 76.65%
1127:54 | 76.8%
1130:47 | 76.89%
1133:24 | 77%
1136:07 | 77.09%
1138:52 | 76.92%
1141:28 | 76.76%
1144:00 | 76.74%
1146:22 | 76.81%
1149:00 | 76.87%
1151:50 |76.94%
1154:25 | 76.99%
1157:30 | 77.07%
1158:38 | 77.11%
1161:11 | 77.13%
1163:47 | 76.99%
1166:21 | 77.07%
1168:49 | 77.13%
1170:20 | 77.19%
1172:58 | 77.23%
1175:32 | 77.27%
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1181:18 | 77.46%
1182:45 | 77.49%
1185:26 | 77.54%
1187:54 | 77.58%
1189:42 | 77.61%
1192:15 | 77.62%

1197:25 |77.66%
1199:16 | 77.68%
1202:00 | 77.71%
1202:52 |77.71%
1205:19 | 77.72%
1207:57 | 77.75%
1210:33 | 77.61%
1212:26 | 77.73%
1214:56 | 77.79%
1217:33 | 77.82%
1220:00 | 77.89%
1222:34 | 77.95%
1225:03 | 77.98%
1227:28 | 78.03%
1230:15 | 77.85%
1232:40 | 77.58%
1235:27 | 77.81%
1238:17 | 77.98%
1240:53 | 77.99%
1243:23 | 78.08%
1245:53 | 78.02%
1248:21 | 78.04%
1249:06 | 78.06%
1251:34 | 78.08%
1252:53 | 78.08%
1254:15 | 78.11%
1257:01 | 78.13%
1259:34 | 78.19%
1262:10 | 78.22%
1264:41 | 78.27%
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1268:19 | 78.16%
1269:49 | 78.18%
1271:00 | 78.28%
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1276:10 | 78.21%
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1322:11 | 80.03%
1324:42 | 80.14%
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1359:54 | 81.3%
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1399:28 | 81.87%
1401:46 | 81.98%
1404:15 | 82.08%
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1426:22 | 82.41%
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1436:23 | 82.33%
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1441:58 | 82.33%
1444:34 | 82.34%
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1451:12 | 82.4%
1453:41 | 82.52%
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1460:10 | 82.33%
1462:33 | 82.34%
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1467:12 | 82.41%
1470:39 | 82.42%
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1498:25 | 82.72%
1500:48 | 82.74%
1503:17 | 82.76%
1506:02 | 82.79%
1508:14 | 82.8%
1510:38 | 82.81%
1512:59 | 82.83%
1515:14 | 82.84%
1517:38 | 82.84%
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1562:46 | 83.12%
1565:04 | 83.16%
1567:17 | 83.2%
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1576:42 | 83.29%
1579:10 | 83.25%
1581:31 | 83.27%
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1586:20 | 83.3%
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1735:59 | 84.29%
1739:12 | 84.29%
1742:42 | 84.29%
1746:13 | 84.29%
1749:45 | 84.29%
1753:10 | 84.29%
1756:22 | 84.29%
1758:03 | 84.29%
1761:33 | 84.29%
1764:32 | 84.29%
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1779:13 | 84.29%
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1793:45 | 84.29%
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1803:38 | 84.29%
1807:08 | 84.29%
1810:15 | 83.54%
1812:48 | 82.93%
1815:09 | 82.38%
1818:35 | 82.38%
1822:00 | 82.38%
1825:25 | 82.38%
1828:49 | 82.38%
1832:40 | 82.38%
1835:41 | 82.38%
1839:17 | 82.38%
1842:39 | 82.38%
1846:11 | 82.38%
1849:38 | 82.38%
1852:09 | 82.38%
1856.25 | 82.38%
1859:28 | 82.38%
1862:55 | 82.38%
1867:11 | 82.38%
1871:16 | 81.91%
1874:38 | 81.59%
1877:46 | 81.28%

1883:01 | 80.81%
1886:33 | 80.48%
1889:09 | 80.29%
1891:51 | 80.01%
1895:08 | 79.68%
1898:50 | 79.35%
1902:05 | 79.42%
1905:33 | 79.58%
1908:38 | 79.91%
1911:45 | 80.07%
1914:06 | 80.12%
1916:23 | 79.9%
1919:51 | 79.99%
1923:27 | 80.09%
1927:00 | 80.02%
1930:25 | 80.33%
1934:37 | 80.48%
1938:13 | 80.25%
1941:35 | 80.31%
1945:04 | 80.37%
1948:33 | 80.41%
1952:00 | 80.52%
1955:28 | 80.61%
1958:49 | 80.64%
1961:48 | 80.59%
1964:21 | 80.54%
1967:21 | 80.48%
1970:47 | 80.56%
1974:02 | 80.63%
1977:35 | 80.69%
1981:04 | 80.66%
1984:18 | 80.67%
1987:46 | 80.76%
1991:20 | 80.78%
1995:01 | 80.83%
1998:42 | 80.84%

Final stats at 2,000 hours

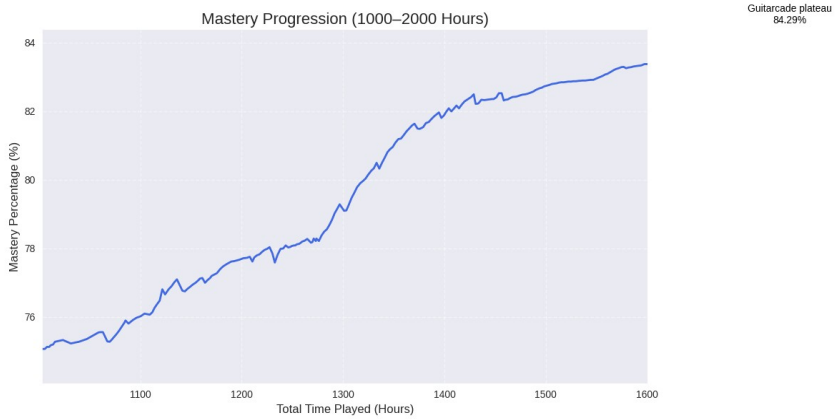
total playtime 2001:00

132 of 4776 tracks @ 100%+

overall mastery 80.84%

22653 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 90.84%



“I still did not know anything, I was still babbling as though I were a babe. Too many guitars, fumbling in the dark, but at least I was crawling. I was trying so hard to find the light switch in a darkened room. Momentum was slow, progress was painful. Not in the physical sense, but in needing to know, I didn’t care about my tone, I didn’t care about my sound. I was just trying to make things work so badly that I wanted to scream. I sounded confident, but I had at least narrowed it down to Vai for structure, Guitarmax for gear, Tony Polecastro for inspiration, and Glenn Fricker for the motivation. The more you learn from? The more scattered you become. I had my sources, but the one I didn’t see? Was myself and my refusal to surrender. Never underestimate the power of yourself, when the noise is tuned out.”

~Matthew Lee

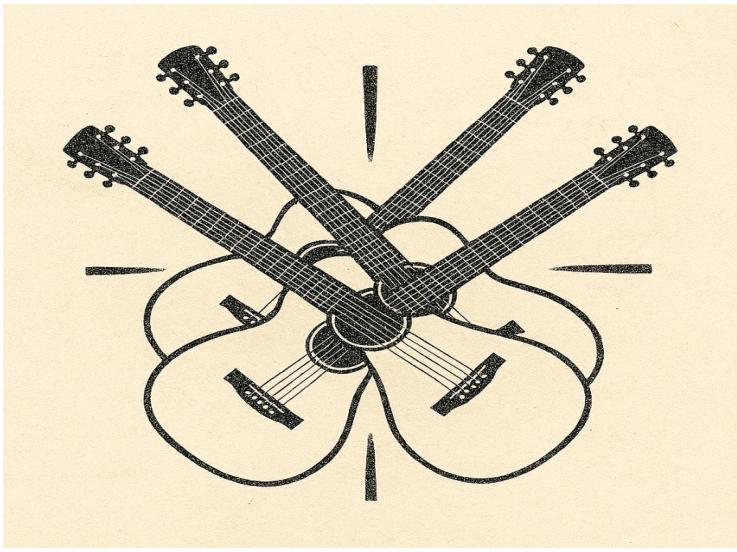
4

“I’s a dessert man. Always has been. Love me my cake, my cookies, but nothin’ hit the spot like pie. Apple, pumpkin, peach, cherry, rhubarb. Only thing better than all of those? Humble pie. Yeah that stuff good as momma’s own and Matthew got hit with a taste of that from one of if not the most despised people in the industry...Yup Ol’ Matthew got to chew on a big, fat, thick, oversweetened piece from a fat waiter who be pickin his nose with hairy forearms. Tried helpin’ a player out, I’ll give him credit for that much...but yummy yummy in my tummy seein’ his know-it-all ass get shut down mm-hmmm. Stings watching that happen in the best way.

He might like runnin his yap, but the boy’s starting to screw his head on straight. He’s getting nuances down, little obvious things that slip by getting ironed out slowly. Realizing in hindsight he was a dumbass and recognizin it. Just ‘cause you starting to pick things up though? Don’t mean it sticks.

I got to be shakin my head at the gear though. Gear don’t be makin the man, man makes the gear. Man sound like shit? Gear sound like shit. But, he’s doing drills, shufflin’ round, tryin new things. Maybe, just maybe he weren’t done for yet. I don’t know, seen even better players fall by the wayside. Just do what I do, keep watchin, nod when he’s earned it, slap your knee and laugh when he don’t, but always dust his ass off when he fall and tell him ‘git on up and move it along bright boy’ Only way a man learn don’tcha know? Too many times I seen this, far too many. ”

~C.R. D’aemon



3000 HOURS

I’ve got to start this chapter off with a story in and of itself before I get too deep into the proceedings. I was at my local guitar store trying to get some technical help with a new guitar that had a problem I couldn’t figure out on my own, the individual in front of me had just started out playing and for his first guitar, he’d purchased an American made Stratocaster (nothing against him or his decision, but it’s not something I’d have started out with myself.) He was upset that the neck wasn’t thick enough for his tastes and he kept harassing the guitar tech because he’d convinced himself that just upping the string gauge would do the job. He’d gotten up to 12’s and was still complaining that it didn’t feel “thicker”.

After about the thousandth time of me checking my watch, I told him to just contact warmoth and have them do up a different neck for him. He nodded and harumphed at the tech and stormed out of the store. I finally stepped up to the counter, explained my problem and rolled my eyes at the man that had been in front of me. The tech listened to me patiently as we developed a plan for my guitar and as we finished the plan out, he said “I wouldn’t roll my eyes at him. You were even more clueless than he was when I met you”. I was flabbergasted at the statement but took a moment to remember back on my journey. The man was right. When I started, I couldn’t string my guitar, name the strings, didn’t know my notes, couldn’t hold a pick. It was humbling to say the least. Never forget from where you came

On to this thousand hours.

Runners have a phrase called “hitting the wall”. It’s when your body and mind still have the ability to go further than what the runner’s confidence is willing to accept. I have seen shades of this developing in my own guitar journey. The passion that I’m having at this point isn’t non-existent, but it is muted. I’ve been told that the only thing to do is either stop and walk away (not happening) or just keep doing it in spite of how you feel about it. There’s no other real choice given how much I’ve invested myself into this right now.

My strength that’s developed the most over this period has been primarily in hammer ons and pull offs. I’d somehow convinced myself that a pull off was just lifting the finger off of the string. Took me forever to be able to learn that it was just a downward soft pluck to get the damned thing to register correctly.

I’ve shuffled from playing rhythm guitar to lead guitar, so that involves taking some time to learn how to two handed tap especially with my favorite era of music being the 80s. It’s a bit awkward still but I just haven’t developed the muscle memory in my right hand to be able to jump to the tap reliably at this point. Obviously, that skill will develop the deeper into this I go

I spent time working on sound dynamics (controlling how loud the strings ring out just by how hard they're hit) This turned out to be quite a bit more difficult and nuanced than I'd thought it was going to be. There's been a great many things that have frustrated me with this journey of learning guitar, but none so much as this. I hope that it comes in more handy down the road otherwise I'm going to be very upset with myself.

I spent a total of 12 weeks practicing string skipping. This was pretty easy to get down pat once I learned that to just go up a string or down a string was a sliding of the fingers, to skip a string is a flick of the wrist. This has become second nature at this point and insanely easy.

So far as the scales and modes go? Pentatonic Major Pentatonic Minor Aeolian Major Mixolydian (just started)

I'm just over 31,000 song playthroughs at this point. Practicing between six and seven hours a day.

Yes, practice and gains are incremental at this point, but if 10000 hours is 100%, then 3000 hours is ½ way out of the "F" tier so there is that. I'm still not at a point where I'd deem myself "comfortable" playing in front of people I don't know right now. I can play a few riffs here and there, but nothing that I'd call a full on song. It's easy to see why people walk away from this seemingly simple instrument by this point…

Has anything changed with gear? Always...I'm now a homeowner and have a dedicated room to JUST practicing so amplifiers have become more of a targeted product as have guitar pedals as I start my foray into tube amplifiers. At this point it's difficult remembering what I have now as opposed to what I had at the last chapter, I've added several super strats such as Ibanez, Jackson, Schecter and I'm wanting to get some Kramers, LTD and a Dean into the mix. Time will tell.

All I can do right now is just keep my head down and keep moving forward. I started this journey on March 22nd 2016. Today is July 12th 2023. Yes, it's taken me this long to just reach 3,000 hours. I've set a goal for myself of 3,500 hours by Jan 1st 2024, I'm silently pushing myself to actually hit 4,000 hours though. The math is there, it's possible to do. It all depends on how much life interferes with my plans though. I hope to start this next chapter on new years day. See you then. (I hope)

2001:24 | 80.83% July 12 2023
2004:51 | 80.87%
2006:26 | 80.92%
2008:49 | 80.95%
2010:18 | 80.93%
2013:25 | 80.92%
2016:33 | 80.82%
2020:08 | 80.88%

2025:56 | 80.98%
2029:19 | 81.02%
2032:29 | 81.08%
2035:18 | 81.13%
2038:19 | 81.14%
2041:01 | 81.18%
2044:14 | 81.22%
2047:40 | 81.28%
2052:10 | 81.12%
2055:32 | 81.21%
2059:02 | 81.23%
2061:36 | 81.24%
2065:05 | 81.27%
2068:50 | 81.33%
2072:17 | 81.4%
2075:16 | 81.44%
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2086:01 | 81.39%
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2103:18 | 81.42%
2105:18 | 81.42%
2108:27 | 81.44%
2111:41 | 81.45%
2118:15 | 81.49%
2121:57 | 81.5%
2129:23 | 81.53%
2132:24 | 81.55%
2138:23 | 81.65%
2141:28 | 81.66%
2145:55 | 81.74%
2150:04 | 81.58%
2152:28 | 81.39%
2155:33 | 81.23%
2159:43 | 81.26%
2163:02 | 81.3%
2166:06 | 81.36%
2169:20 | 81.42%
2172:38 | 81.49%
2175:53 | 81.55%
2179:23 | 81.61%
2182:22 | 81.65%
2183:42 | 81.68%
2184:45 | 81.69%

2186:10 | 81.73%
2189:07 | 81.78%
2191:26 | 81.83%
2193:23 | 81.86%
2195:01 | 81.91%
2198:11 | 81.99%
2199:05 | 82.02%
2201:10 | 82.05%
2203:24 | 82.07%
2206:28 | 82.22%
2209:29 | 82.33%
2212:42 | 82.38%
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2220:00 | 82.42%
2223:17 | 82.45%
2226:52 | 82.47%
2230:06 | 82.5%
2236:23 | 82.54%
2238:42 | 82.55%
2239:39 | 82.56%
2242:44 | 82.58%
2244:28 | 82.6%
2247:46 | 82.63%
2250:46 | 82.67%
2253:56 | 82.74%
2257:11 | 82.8%
2259:18 | 82.82%
2260:22 | 82.83%
2262:48 | 82.88%
2265:43 | 82.97%
2268:36 | 83.09%
2271:23 | 83.13%
2274:20 | 83.2%
2277:33 | 83.26%
2280:39 | 83.33%
2283:54 | 83.39%
2286:57 | 83.49%
2290:53 | 83.61%
2294:06 | 83.69%
2296:55 | 83.5%
2301:30 | 83.33%
2304:39 | 83.28%
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2310:25 | 83.42%
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2320:37 | 83.63%
2325:05 | 83.74%
2328:34 | 83.88%
2332:12 | 84.02%
2336:03 | 84.15%
2339:43 | 84.2%
2342:22 | 84.14% (all dlc downloaded and installed, production ceased)
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2978:52 | 87.14%
2983:13 | 87.15%
2987:21 | 87.16%
2991:37 | 87.16%
2995:54 | 87.18% February 21 2024

Final stats at 3,000 hours

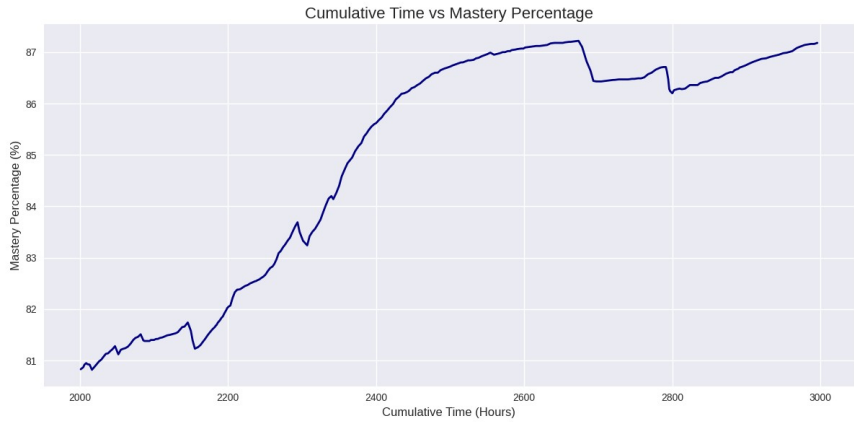
total playtime 3000:01

180 of 4776 tracks @ 100%+

overall mastery 87.19%

31461 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 91.65%



‘My greatest ally was determination. I had become monastic in my practice. I abandoned song practice for drills, then abandoned drills for songs, then back again. My refusal to submit was what pushed me forward. I had no compass, so I marked my path on paper, trying to decipher what was missing. The cost of a tutor was still too extravagant. I had to rely on myself and my teachers on youtube. Chappers and the Captain, Max Carlisle, Dagan Wilkin, Tony Polecastro, Glenn Fricker, Rick Beato, Rhett Shull. Their guidance in this phase was scattershot but essential. Without them? I would have been lost. I had to just not stop and keep going. There was no other option in my mind, or at least that’s what I’d told myself.”

~Matthew Lee

5

“Well, Ol’Matthew’s becomin’ a man with a guitar now ain’t he? Yeah, when the switch be flippin’? That’s when times start getting’ good. Know that feeling myself just like walkin, ridin’ a bike. It’s grabbing and glidin like a baby bird. Never sticks though...not yet at least. Jazzmaster with 13 gauge strings tuned to standard and pullin’ bends for an hour a day? Yeah no doubt you’ll screw somethin’ up and boy lord sakes’ almighty? He sure did. Told him that’s not a bright idea, but he still thinks he knows better than C.R….horsepiss and hogwash I say! I told him not to, would he listen to me? Noooo. Price paid as per the contract...It’s in the fine print if he’d taken the time to read it.

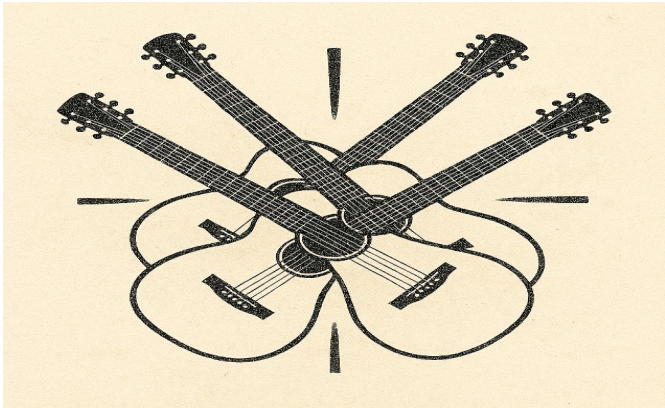
He’s slowly getting it together...still lyin’ to hisself and by proxy to me. “Less focus on gear…” My ass. Finger’s crossed ‘tween his back smilin’ at me like I don’t know no fib. Lyin’ to me? There’s consequences for stuff like that. I ain’t goin to say it in public..no witnesses but he’ll get his.

He’s starting to educate himself at least, part of the growin’ up, theory’s important but when you can barely pull off a few scales to a toe tappin’ tune? He’s getting’ a tad bit ahead of himself. Sure enough he’s stubborn and that’ll serve him well.

Take a gander though, “I’m done with gear” less than a heartbeat away? He’s talking about amplifiers...MAKE UP YO FOOL MIND SON. Good god almighty, this boy’s got the attention of a jackrabbit on coffee...Probably should’ve given the contract to someone else...I’d have less of a migraine from this kid with the psychological whiplash this boy’s givin’ me. File for worker’s comp, emotional damages….yeah, ain’t nobody payin’ me...no use for coins where I’m from if you can read between the lines….

He’s getting in the right direction though, slowly when he ain’t trippin over his own his feet or his shoelaces comin’ undone. Train wreck right in front of my eyes, can’t look away, don’t wanna watch. I need a vacation…”

~C.R. D’aemon



4000 HOURS

I can honestly say that this time period (3,000-4,000 hours) felt like grabbing a new gear. The old phrase of something “clicked” is very appropriate here. There’s a lot to unpack here so I’ll try to just get down to it.

I chose to go full in on the fundamentals including sound dynamics, bends, tremolo picking, harmonics.

I successfully injured my fretting hand twice during this time period due to spending an hour on bends each day. I pushed too hard and had to cut back to ten minutes a day of practice. Had it not been for the injuries, I probably would have actually made my original goal of 4,000 hours prior to the new year of 2024. I didn’t listen to my body and paid the price for it.

Where’s my confidence at right now? Reasonably high without being cocky. Unless it’s thrash or shredding I’ve got it down now. Power chords, barre chords, pentatonic scales, I’ve got it. I can play a lot faster than normal but once again, I’m competent, not a shredder. Would I be confident in instructing someone at this point? Yes, if they’re a beginner to beginning intermediate. I still would not be comfortable in a band or a studio at this point. There’s just way too many mistakes that I still make and don’t have songs committed to memory. I can play off of the screen but I am not there yet.

I’d go into the gear that I have now, but there’s less and less focus on the gear. I can play any guitar, use any amplifier, I have a full pedal collection now except for a looper pedal, I have modeling amps, tube amps, etc. It’s just not at the forefront of my concerns anymore, not like it used to be unless I’m looking to spend money for the sake of spending money.

So, what’s the focus right now? The focus for this period was absolutely trying to hammer music theory into my head. There’s a book series called the “No bull” guitar music theory that’s been easy enough for me to digest. I’m about halfway through the 2nd book of 3 and it’s starting to sink in finally. I’m looking forward to finishing this series off then I’ll hit my books on the Nashville Number System and then teaching myself how to read music.

I spend a good few minutes every day after practice just going over the statistics that I’ve earned that day trying to see what if anything I’d be looking at when I’m done with this. I’m struggling to find a metaphor here but this is what I’ve got.

When someone has a car that they’re looking to modify, the first few improvements are usually pretty amazing and drastic. The following improvements usually become more and more nuanced. Unfortunately you find yourself eventually digging in as deep as you can pulling whatever tricks you can

pull out of your rear end to get any minute little edge. Sadly, these are also usually insanely expensive.

I feel at this point I can say I have built for myself a solid foundation with a few cracks here and there. I anticipate that I'll have that solidified by 5,000 hours. I know I've still got my work cut out for me. There's a LOT to learn with this. It's all too easy looking back to see how people give up on this. When I look at this though, I see how far I've come, and it's just a solid "Yeah…" feeling. I ain't the best in the world, I don't need to be. For the time being at this point? I'm good. I know that I won't be good for long and that I'm going to want more. It's just a matter of time. I'm generating a support structure online, and hoping that what I'm doing helps someone when they start their journey like I did.

All that comes to mind anymore is the words of Frank Zappa "Keep going and don't stop". I do want to say this though and I'll probably catch heat for it. The amount of commentators that I've seen that typically state "The 10k rule is b.s."? I genuinely believe that it isn't. At least at this point. Now, mind you I still have 6,000 hours to go, but looking at the map for this journey? It adds up pretty good if mastery is indeed what you're targeting.

Pentatonic Minor f-e

Pentatonic Major G-f#

Aeolian F#-f

Major F#-f Dorian f#-f

Mixolydian f#-f

Phyrgian f-e

Lydian f#-e

I'm hopeful to hit 5,500 hours before new years day of 2025. I'll see you when I hit 5,000 hours. Best wishes until then my friends

3000:01 | 87.19% July 13, 2023
3004:37 | 87.21%
3010:24 | 87.24%
3016:18 | 87.27%
3021:34 | 87.29%
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3147:01 | 87.72%
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3171:49 | 87.79%
3176:24 | 87.81%
3178:53 | 87.81%
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3187:55 | 87.83%
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3852:01 | 91.03%
3856:47 | 91.1%
3862:13 | 91.16%
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3869:01 | 91.22%
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3986:30 | 92.18%
3989:11 | 92.2%
3995:44 | 92.23%
3999:33 | 92.27% Feb 21, 2024

Final stats at 4,000 hours

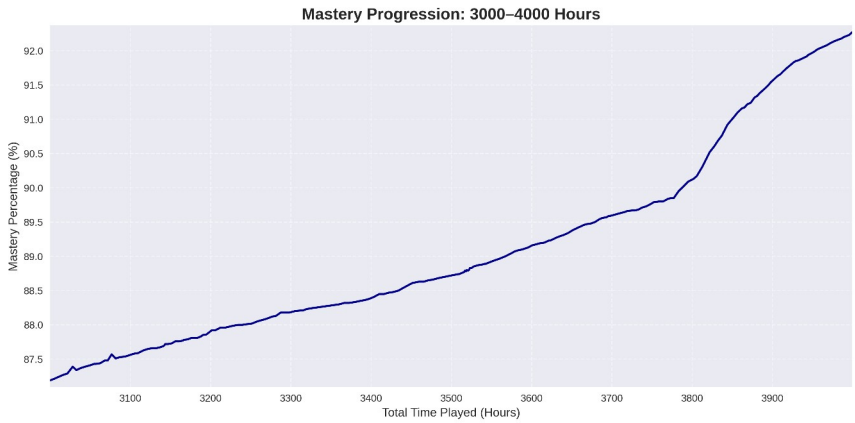
total playtime 4000:04

247 of 4776 tracks @ 100%+

overall mastery 92.27%

40514 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 93.36%



“Yeah, I over-exerted myself. It’s the price of passion, or that’s what I tell myself to sleep at night. This period of the arc? It was a forge. So many long hours doing drills, scales, finger exercises, chords. Days and weeks doing nothing but the same stuff over and over again. I abandoned songs for these drills. Why? Because I’d seen the power of these and felt that they were more worthy of my time. It was only after I’d spent that amount of time on these drills that when I went back to the songs? They fell at my feet as though they were nothing. Sad thing was those were the simple songs. However, when you’re fumbling through songs and you suddenly find traction? It’s like a snail on the back of turtle, the only thing you can think is “wow, this is really, really fast.” I can say this much in hindsight, I’m aggravated that nobody had left any benchmarks for me and what to expect along the way. It’s part of the reason I’m doing this. It’s not for me and my sake, but for those that will follow.”

~Matthew Lee

6

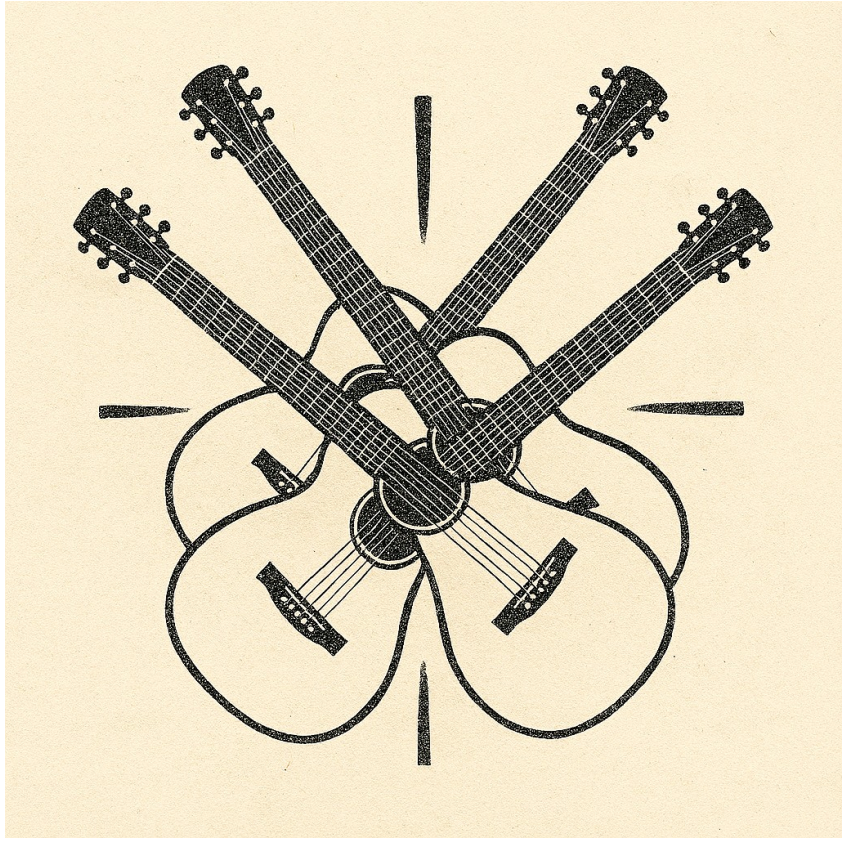
“Well, the man is thorough I’ll give him that much. Never believe a guitar player when they say they done buyin’ things. No different than when the weather man say’s it sunny outside before the thunder claps off. He’s tackling this less like a music man and more like an accountant. Gonna be tellin’ to see what lands where, can’t recall as though I’ve seen this approach before, have you? Can’t think of a single time I’ve seen this done in all the decades I’ve been doing this.

Can’t imagine how much headspace and focus it’s gonna take to do this. Playin’ through all these songs over and over like he’s going through a filing cabinet. Got me scratchin’ my noodle like a dog with a bad case of fleas. Why though?

I’m gonna have to keep an eye on this one...something different about this contract, might wind up regretting letting him sign on the line. Very rare one actually slips me, happens from time to time.

He’s able to tell where he’s at on the neck now without looking, I wonder if he can do this across his entire library of guitars, or if he’s a specialist. Arpeggios, two handed tapping, shredding….so, he’s confident in his left hand, but not his right..I might be able to exploit that to catch him. What do you think hmm? How good might you be? You still thinking about signing? Me? What am I thinking? Oh nothin’ you need to worry about yet, you’re just on provisional contract. Nothing serious, just relax...all in good fun ‘til the preview’s done. Your name would look mighty fine on the dotted line, yessir! ”

~C.R. D’aemon



5,000 HOURS HALFWAY THERE

If you'd told me when I started that I would've actually held interest from March 22nd 2016 to today, November 22nd 2024 I would've laughed in your face. I have a long history of self sabotage with any project I take on. So, what's happened in the last thousand hours? I have completed my study of scales to my satisfaction and have since moved on to music theory as well as the Nashville number system. I've completed a total of 54,000 song playthroughs, I've mastered 1,996 songs up to 100% out of 4776 total. My average mastery is at 95.73% my accuracy at the time of this writing shifts between 94.11 and 94.13%. I have for the most part left behind solid state amplifiers and am pushing towards tube amplifiers which seems to be a natural progression

I started all the songs I could from zero percent and pushed as many as possible to 100%. I'm currently backtracking trying to acquire twelve playthroughs on each song. My plan when that's done is to ascend back to 100% and run the gamut again, pushing for 20 playthroughs on each song until it's obvious that things are just out of my reach without single mindedly focusing on individual tracks with intent so I feel like I'm separating the wheat from the chaff here

So why not just choose the songs I want to play and work from there? The answer is simple: No student ever gets to choose the questions on the exam. While one might not retain all information from the test, the knowledge still does exist inherently in the subconscious mind. I will eventually get to the stage where I just practice the songs that I want to play, but I want to do more than just play songs, I want to know my instruments. Maybe there's a way to do that, but I'm not willing or ready to do so right now.

I'm starting to feel out what I want to do when this is all over, I wouldn't mind being an instructor but my back and body are already starting to show the wear and tear of transferring from middle age to senior citizen in the form of a cane. I don't know if I'll ever perform live. It's hard for me to fathom people wanting to see an old man playing on a barstool but we'll cross that bridge when we get to it.

Chord transitions and the neck now feel at home and I no longer need to look at the dots on the side of the neck unless there's a profound key change. Bar chords, power chords, suspended and augmented chords are all flawless now. So what am I still struggling with? Arpeggiated picking, two handed tapping and shredding

What are my hopes for the next thousand hours? My soloing needs to improve although I don't think I'll hit the two handed tapping until much later. I'm still not ready to begin jamming or anything of that nature at this point although I could probably pull punk out of my backside or ballads if you held a gun to my head.

Anyway, it’s time for me to close this out. I’ve got practicing to do and thankfully by the time the next chapter is written I’ll be out of “F” tier and into “D” tier.

Just take my advice if you’re reading this, it’s worth it. When you finally reach this point? This is when things start to get satisfying. All the fumbling and failures start adding up to something substantive and it stops becoming focused and starts being instinctive.

4002:52 | 92.29% Nov 22 2024
4006:31 | 92.3%
4007:11 | 92.31%
4011:04 | 92.33%
4016:59 | 92.37%
4021:06 | 92.39%
4025:54 | 92.43%
4030:49 | 92.47%
4035:23 | 92.5%
4039:04 | 92.52%
4041:43 | 92.53%
4048:11 | 92.57%
4053:32 | 92.6%
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4117:24 | 92.9%
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4127:33 | 92.93%
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4134:02 | 92.96%
4138:26 | 92.97%
4143:11 | 92.98%
4149:03 | 93%
4157:51 | 93.01%

4161:48 | 93.03%
4171:20 | 93.05%
4175:36 | 93.06%
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4438:07 | 93.73%
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4452:41 | 93.75%
4456:32 | 93.76%
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4468:37 | 93.78%
4473:29 | 93.79%
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4486:58 | 93.81%
4491:09 | 93.82%
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4978:24 | 95.6%
4982:10 | 95.61%
4985:51 | 95.63%
4995:46 | 95.68% Nov 14 2025

Final stats at 5,000 hours

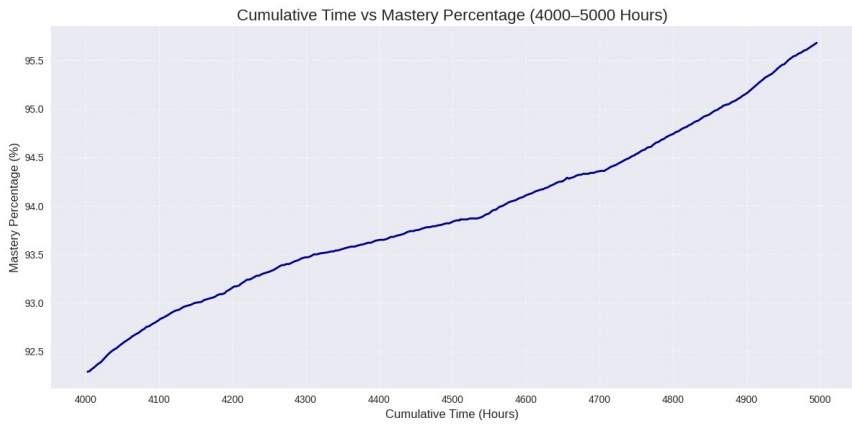
total playtime 5000:01

1979 tracks of 4776 @ 100%+

overall mastery 92.27%

54390 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 94.12%

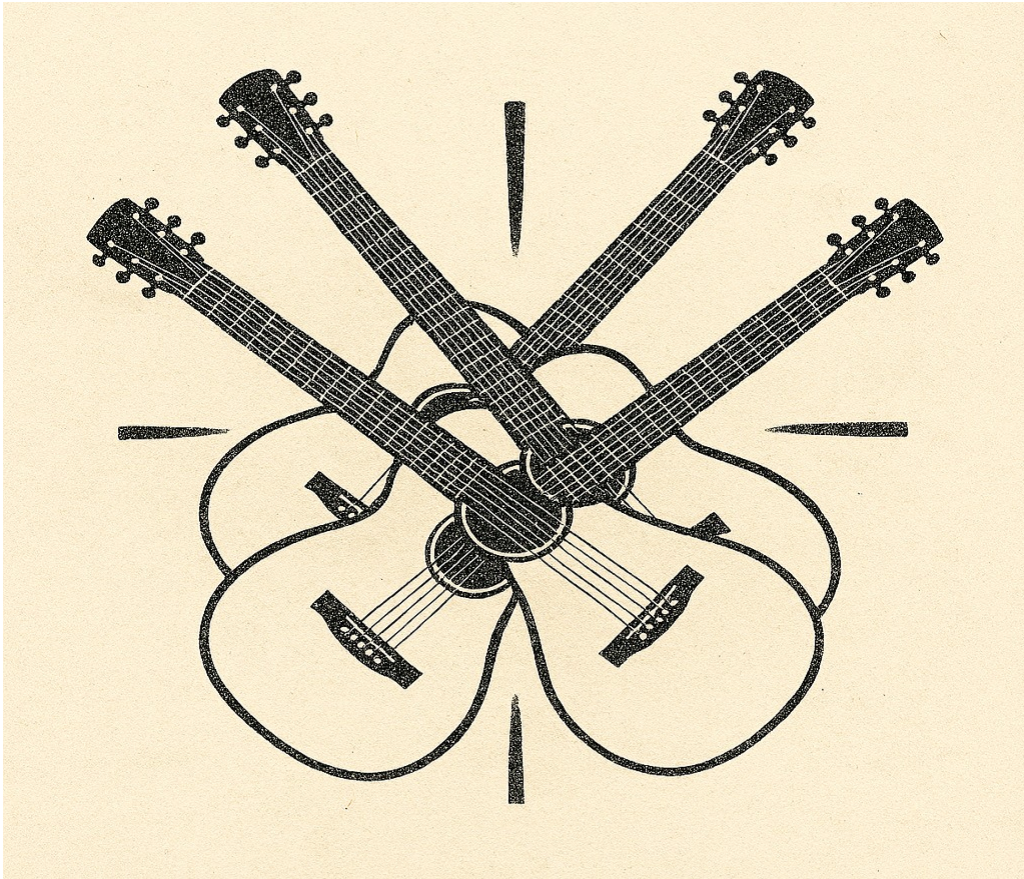


“Once I had the scales, the chords, the theory, I felt...empowered. I didn’t know what I was in for, I felt as though I’d graduated boot camp, advanced training and was eager for combat. It was indeed time for me to test my mettle. Tracks were falling to the wayside, I was playing with the door open, through an amplifier. Loud, soft, I was feeling absolutely joyous. I could carry on conversations, read forums and reddit, understand what exactly my youtubers were feeling and I was absolutely feeling like I’d finally found my place in life. Were there still songs out of my reach? Of course, and there shall always be tracks that will remain such, and I am grateful for that. The only thing that I grieve now? Is that so many tracks will be in my rearview that while once adversarial? Are now as simple as “row your boat”. So long as songs exist, there shall be complexity, and simplicity, and I shall welcome them both with open arms.” ~Matthew Lee

7

“Alright, he’s holding steady...he’s still under contract though, seen it cut closer in the past. Sixty-eight thousand? No more coffee for that man! I didn’t think he’d be making this kind of progress...Oh, he could easily join a band, but he won’t. He ain’t got the guts, unfortunately though...that ain’t in the fine print..Should’ve thought of that sooner. Okay, still got him on sweep picking, tapping, and arpeggio. That’s good...How’s your skills on that hmm? You keeping them up to snuff? What’s YOUR weak points? Might not be a bad idea to adjust your contract just a touch before I go giving you the pen on the binding one. Got to make sure that all my bases are covered, never know if you might be a wiley one too. He’s at least coming to terms that he ain’t gonna stop buyin’ stuff, now it’s “a collection”. Ha! He’s gonna be on the next episode of hoarding old folk he ain’t careful. Oh, if he hangs it up? I’ve got him stone cold. Dead to rights. You wouldn’t do that to me would you? Most do….I wouldn’t mind if you defaulted...neither would him...my boss that is. Can’t say his name. He’s got so many.”

~C.R. D’aemon



6,000 hours

Well, it's November 15th 2025. I finally crossed the six thousand hour marker. I completed my full thirteen playthroughs of each song during this time and am now descending back to the 20 playthrough count. I've amassed over 68,000 song playthroughs at this time, an overall mastery of 98.76%, an accuracy of 94.46% all over 1,551 songs. I had initially believed that I wouldn't reach this level of mastery or accuracy for at least another three years. My gear collection has become more a case of spending money and acquisition than anything else.

Could I at this point be in a band? Small time local pub cover band yeah. I'm not a songwriter nor is that the point of this exercise. The whole point of this exercise is to see what happens after ten thousand hours of practice has been acquired and the results thereof are found and quantified.

I can't begin to count the amount of chords or scales or modes that I've played. It's no longer a consideration. The muscle memory that has been developed? It's not even active thought anymore unless it's shredding, two handed tapping, or sweep picking. Even arpeggios are starting to slowly click into place.

It would have to be (speaking only from my perspective) an answer to give a student that wants to know "How long?" and the instructor is tired of trying to explain to the student outright that the onus IS on them to do the homework, take notes, study, pay attention, and do their level best to excel. The answer of "10,000 hours"? That's equivalent to a junior resident tier for a doctor in a hospital just to learn to play guitar. I'm sorry, but I can attest that I was able to play and enjoy music much earlier than this. Have I played for ten thousand hours? No, of course not. Nor was it necessary to be able to play and enjoy guitar.

So, I can't argue for the metrics of the principles of the 10k hour rule being correct or pertinent. I was having fun and capable of playing songs and enjoying between four and six years of practice, on par with say a bachelor's degree or a master's degree. That was really for a non-professional about all the time that I truly required to become sufficiently fluent in order to sound good to a non-musician.

I do want to clarify something that's visible in the time logs, there's a window wherein things flatten out at 97.16%. I was on vacation with my family in Disney and was just grabbing basic practice wherever I could, whenever I could. Just maintaining not focusing on expansion.

Where is this going to wind up? To be perfectly honest, given my accuracy and mastery? I could probably hang it up right now and be good. However, until such time as ten thousand hours is acquired? I haven't in my own mind proven anything. Until the full ten thousand hours is acquired? Then the journey continues. I estimate that I'll have seven thousand hours by sometime in august or

september of 2026. I wish I could say that I had more of a gameplan at this time but right now? It really is just building up the song playthroughs. My foundational skills are truly integrated to the point where it’s on par with recalling the alphabet or multiplication tables. So, it’s building up speed and accuracy and mastering songs. This has become such a focal point simply because it’s the only way to learn to adapt on the fly.

I wonder what this is going to look like in hindsight when all this work is done. I’ve already come further than even I thought I’d ever actually achieve. I do believe this will be unprecedented and unreplicatable by institutions or academia just due to the cost so this will probably be the only metric available until only God knows when.

5000:01 | 95.7%
5001:49 | 95.7%
5005:06 | 95.72%
5011:31 | 95.75%
5015:12 | 95.76%
5018:45 | 95.78%
5022:22 | 95.8%
5025:52 | 95.82%
5029:18 | 95.84%
5032:50 | 95.85%
5036:26 | 95.87%
5043:28 | 95.9%
5046:24 | 95.92%
5048:05 | 95.92%
5051:48 | 95.94%
5055:48 | 95.96%
5059:24 | 95.98%
5062:58 | 95.99%
5066:55 | 96.01%
5070:45 | 96.03%
5074:34 | 96.05%
5078:19 | 96.06%
5081:57 | 96.08%
5085:36 | 96.1%
5089:17 | 96.12%
5093:00 | 96.13%
5096:40 | 96.15%
5100:14 | 96.17%
5103:54 | 96.19%
5107:27 | 96.21%
5111:05 | 96.23%
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5118:07 | 96.26%
5121:52 | 96.27%
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5136:06 | 96.33%
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5662:44 | 97.77%
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5682:56 | 97.83%
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5762:01 | 98.04%
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5773:24 | 98.08%

5777:12 | 98.09%
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5869:12 | 98.33%
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5876:43 | 98.35%
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5884:18 | 98.37%
5888:07 | 98.38%
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5899:04 | 98.42%
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5988:21 | 98.71%
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5999:26 | 98.74%

Final stats at 6,000 hours

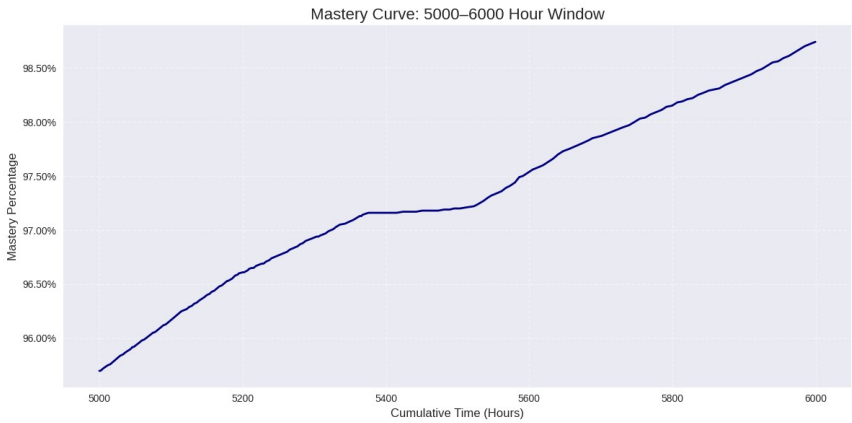
total playtime 6000:00

3299 tracks of 4776 @ 100%+

overall mastery 98.75%

68717 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 94.44%



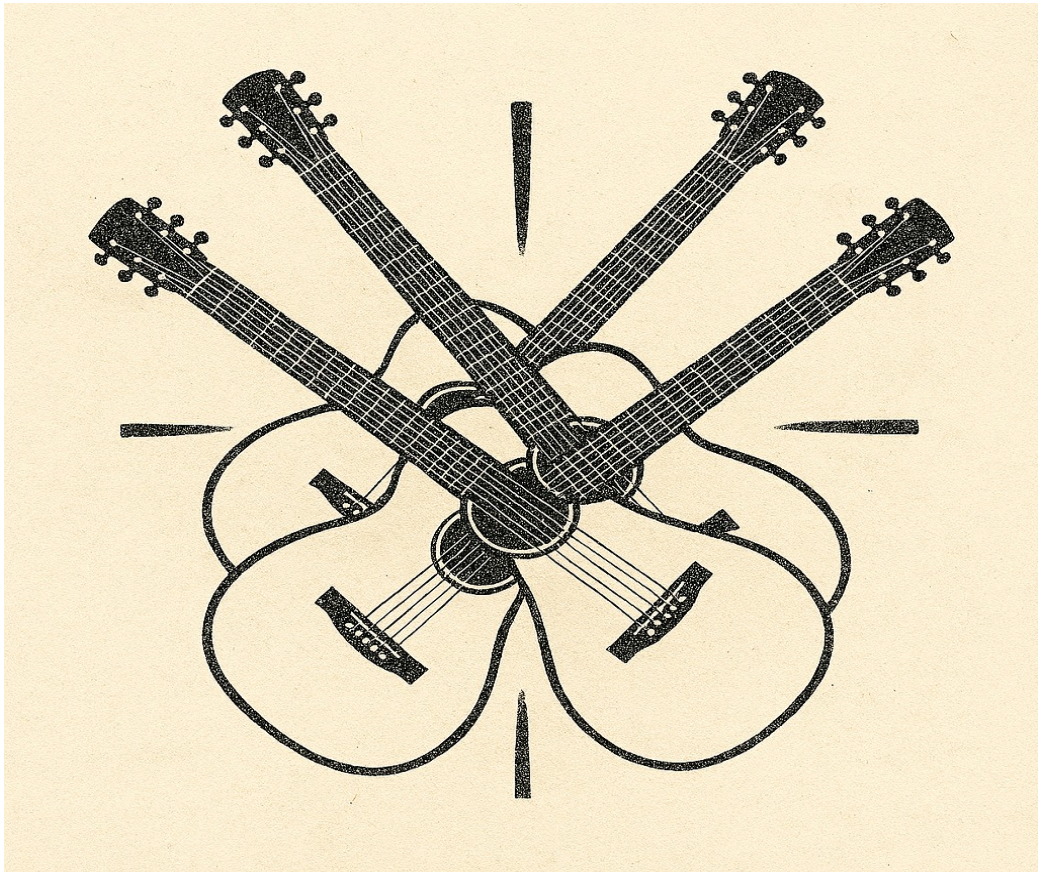
“I was trying to reconcile my stats with the 10k hour rule, I only have a g.e.d. so I knew there had to be something else. Anyone that could acquire this much elapsed time? Especially if they’d been gigging, busking? They’d be respected, able to play 2 hours of music with not too much trouble. Stagecraft would be developed. To the untrained eye? Just a simple fan? It’d be sufficient to be deemed as a “professional”. To an amateur that would be somewhat aware? They’d be deemed a person to look up to, so why the separation? Why the disconnect? Something’s not making sense. I needed to know more, so far as I was concerned? The fundamentals were so integrated at this point? It was now just clearing the field of tracks. Nothing more, nothing less. It was now all about refinement.”

~Matthew Lee

8

“Well, he’s seeming rather scholarly now ain’t he? Saying that the 10,000 hours can be shortened? Is that in violation of the contract? Have to check with the boss...You wouldn’t do that to me would you? Got to be lived to be experienced. I think Ol Matthew’s tryin’ to weasel his way out of this. What is he doing…? PHONE A FRIEND IS NOT IN THE CARDS HERE! FLAG ON THE FIELD! Wait, ain’t nothin’ in the rules sayin’ you can’t ask for help, not in the amendments nor the fine print….Oh I’m amending yours for sure now. Matt’s done went and gone wiley on me. Ain’t supposed to happen. Whatever happened to a clean cut deal anyhow? What? Only 5-7 plays on a track before movin’…..no, no, no….that can’t...he’s supposed to be grindin’. Shakin’ hands with the neck? Now that’s just digustin’ hope he washed’em first. That’s why I only allow signatures. Gol’ dangit I’m gonna have a lot of explainin’ to do when I’m done here. He’s not supposed to be thinkin’ this much! Here, right here, goin’ on about not changin’ instructors. That’s a gotcha I love, change a teacher ‘cause you’re bored, new video, new tik. Undermine my whole damn process. Amend that to the contract. How about you? You do that very much? I’ll find out...yes, I will. ”

~C.R. D’aemon



7,000 hours

It’s important that I break my usual holdout until the 1k marker here because I’ve discovered quite a bit and I want to make sure it isn’t lost.

Jan 28, 2k26

total playtime 6275 hrs 26 minutes

3382 of 4780 tracks at 100%+

overall mastery 99.53%

72652 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 94.74%

First things first, I’ve finally got a handle on the thumb over the top of the neck and how to describe it to anyone needing help, it’s a non-dominant hand handshake. If you’re a golfer? You’ll know what I’m talking about. If not, start shaking hands with southpaws. If you’re a southpaw, you’ll know already what I’m talking about. I’m also creating the “57 rule”. Do not practice a song more than 5 to 7 times sequentially. This is the zone where you stop gaining skill and start practicing mistakes. If your brain starts to feel like it’s “checking out”? Bail. Do not fall for the “just one more run”. When your brain checks out, it’s time to go.

Now as to the 10k hour rule and what I’ve discovered? I had to go back and actually re-read the entirety of Outliers cover to cover. The 10k hour rule isn’t a “rule”. It’s a mean average. There’s also other variables that are covered in the book as well. These variables are just as present in my guitar practice. I’m going to reference these as “accelerants”. Gamers will understand what I mean by it’s like hitting a “boost” arrow in any racing game. These are advantages that accelerate your leaning speed. Some can be controlled, others cannot.

Don’t think of it as actual 10,000 hours as a clock, think concentrated orange juice. You’re squeezing quality of hours and compressing the time based off of the quality of your hours. If you’re just noodling and retuning, talking on the phone, flipping videos? You’re probably getting minimal return on investment. If you sit down, focus, minimize play-time and focus on PRACTICE time (Not rehearsal time, not play songs I already know time) you’re compressing multiple quality hours into a singular hour. This moves the 10k hour marker closer than anticipated.

Examples of what cannot be controlled

Physical build and hand size/arm length/finger length (can be compensated for by various guitar dynamics)

Familial grounding in music

Cultural influences and age of exposure

Examples of what CAN be controlled

Practice time

Practice focus

Maintenance and set-up of gear

All of these things contribute, to varying degrees. Because I've stuck with the Rocksmith platform? I've in essence not changed instructors throughout this entire time. Hopping from teacher to teacher does make an impact. Every time an instructor is changed, a youtuber is changed? The teaching method changes. At the time of this writing? I've spent more than 9 months with the same instructor, same method, same discernment. Yes, this matters. Choose the method, choose the instructor, and hold yourself to a standard. It WILL make a difference. Frustration is proof of growth. You WANT to make mistakes. Why? Because it does show growth, refinement, skill, but most of all? You're displaying a desire to be better than what you are currently. That's a good thing.

Just because you don't believe you have these advantages in variables? Doesn't mean you are ABSENT of variables. It just means that you have to focus on what you CAN control, and move on from what CANNOT be controlled. Doing this? Will outright make your progression faster. Yes, the 10k hour rule is an arbitrary benchmark, which means it's arbitrarily in your way. Wield the tools you have available, build your toolbox, record your results, track your practice.

Myself? I count behind-the-string time which is done automatically with Rocksmith. If I'm NOT actively playing? It isn't ACTIVELY adding time to my practice clock. For every 90 minutes that I practice? I lose about 10 to 15 minutes moving about through menus, loading screens, tuning, retuning, grabbing a drink, etc. The 90 minutes is "In-the-room time". The time playing? I'm dubbing it "behind the strings time". Yes, it adds up, yes it makes a difference.

IF you record your practice, however you choose to do it, leverage your accelerators, stay consistent, apply the 57 rule? You're no longer walking towards 10,000 hours. You're hauling ass in a v12 powered sports car with the top down and your favorite tunes blaring with a 72 oz drink and waving "bye bye" to everyone. Stay focused. You CAN do this.

I've been approaching 100% overall mastery and done a little bit of calculations. At this time: February 2nd 2026? I'm at 6295 hours 8 minutes with overall mastery of 99.59%. This means that it takes me 38 minutes of "behind the strings" time for every .01% of overall mastery. For convenience for you, the reader? An hour of "in room" practice time with distractions, retuning, etc? 1 hour = .01% mastery.

Just apply that and you SHOULD be okay so long as you're pushing yourself to learn new things and expand your skill set. Remember, playing stuff you already know? Isn't practice. That's rehearsal. Practice is doing stuff you aren't good at yet.

I've also started drifting off to sleep at 6,309 total hours with the guitar in my hands while I'm practicing. It's only happened twice but I've heard of this occurring with other famous guitarists and could never understand it. I still don't, but I'll be playing, make it to the end of the song and then just out like a light switch. I wake up a few hours later with no fatigue, no discomfort. Just "Okay, back to work." This is the first time that this behavior has manifested. Prior to this time window? I always had sufficient awareness to stop practicing, put the guitar down and go to bed. I don't know why, but that isn't happening anymore. Upon awakening? I wanted coffee, sugar, carbs, and energy drinks in mass quantities. I instead chugged a half gallon of water. I can only imagine what the impact of that would've been in a recording studio, with administrative pressure and budgets. I can honestly say I'm glad I was at home.

Likewise, I want to say this: For every 90 minutes of practice (Behind-the-string time, not in-the-room time), take 30 minutes of rest. This has been pivotal for me. It permits blood to flow again, allows your muscles and tendons to relax and return to normal. My average practice at this point is as follows

90 minutes of lead

26 minutes of rest

90 minutes of rhythm

26 minutes of rest

90 minutes of bass

STOP UNTIL THE NEXT DAY. I worked up to this. Don't start where I'm at. Start where YOU are at and then BUILD up to where I am. DO. NOT. SKIMP. ON. THE. BREAKS. This brings me RIGHT up to the edge of what starts causing fog or damage. There's enough room if I need to squeeze in three extra song playthroughs (12-15 minutes) I can do it, but not unless ESSENTIAL. I run this 7 days a week with no days off incident free (Discuss with your doctor or a sports physician. I am not liable for your case of terminal dumbass. You've been warned.)

Through thousands of hours across lead, rhythm, and bass, I've discovered that 35 playthroughs is the point where sight-reading ends and the true nature of a track reveals itself. If a chart hasn't reached 100.00% by the 35th run, it's no longer a sight-reading problem. At that point, the track falls into one of three categories: it

contains a technical glitch, it exceeds my current skill ceiling, or it must be committed to memory through focused work in Riff Repeater. This threshold is how I separate the tracks that will resolve through natural repetition from the ones that require deliberate practice. After 35 runs, I stop pushing sub-100% material and shift my attention to raising everything from 100.00% toward 110%, one tenth of a percent at a time.

Players who work from tablature or standard notation often assume that *reading the part* is the same thing as *being able to play the part*. It isn't. Reading gives you the information, but it doesn't give you the mechanics, the timing, or the internalization required to execute the passage cleanly.

What I've discovered through thousands of hours of tracked play is that **35 full playthroughs** is the point where sight-reading stops being the limiting factor. By the 35th run, your brain has fully mapped the notes, the shapes, the rhythms, and the transitions. If the passage still isn't playable at that point, the problem is no longer reading — it's something deeper.

After 35 runs, anything still below "clean and reliable" falls into one of three categories:

- **The transcription is flawed** (rare, but it happens)
- **The passage is above your current technical ceiling**
- **The part must be memorized and isolated before it becomes playable**

This threshold gives you a clean decision point. If you can't play it after 35 honest attempts, you stop trying to sight-read your way through it and switch to deliberate practice: slow isolation, looping, chunking, and memorization. It's how you separate the material that will resolve naturally from the material that requires focused work

My fingerstyle playing is also developing. It's not at a level where I can do it unconciously. It DOES require active thought and planning ahead, but it's developing. I've had middling success with "More than words" by Extreme and "Dust in the wind" by Kansas along with "Silent Lucidity" by Queensryche. I'm no banjo style player, but it's coming along. I think it's my lack of exposure to it that's holding me back.

I do want to take this time to make this thought before it slips my mind, time spent as an individual musician doesn't mean that you're going to be good in a band. There's what I'm calling a "lone instrumentalist" and then a "band instrumentalist". 10K hours on any instrument doesn't mean that a band is good, it means the members as individuals are good. I've noticed through reading back over my own data that around 3500-4000 hours is when I was struggling. For a band as a unit, I estimate this is around the time of the 2nd or 3rd album. This is when most bands either survive...or they don't.

If you go back and research the glam and grunge eras? It’s this period when things typically fell apart. No matter how experienced the individual musicians are singularly? If the band DOES NOT have sufficient time together? History states that they’re going to disintegrate. So what does this observation mean? Don’t try to get signed early. Take the time, learn each other until you’re almost telepathic. LOG YOUR HOURS AS A GROUP AND TRACK THEM. Once the band AS A GROUP has more than 4k hours? Then try for it. If this ethos is followed? The band’s first album should be on par with most band’s third or even fourth albums. Yes, this delays the dreams, but it does guarantee that most problems die outside of the public eye. On the road, a simple annoyance can escalate into a warhead. The amount of money on the line if a band makes it big is not worth losing because someone’s chewing on their fingernails is a pet peeve. To use a common phrase “There’s no secrets at sea”. Deal with it privately.

I’m now at 6384 hours, 26 minutes of practice on march the sixth of 2026. I’m introducing a term here. “Stacked compression per hour”. I mentioned earlier the idea of accelerants to the compounding returns when controllable and non controllable factors are introduced. I believe this will explain why certain guitarists (most outstanding ones being those such as Randy Rhoads, Jeff Buckley, Prince, and Jeff Healey) were able to become so proficient in a small window of time.

The more factors that are included directly increase the acquired skills per hour of practice. The better trained, the more prepared, the greater the amount of acquired skill that is perceptible per hour of training. With each additional controllable and uncontrollable variable that is introduced per hour of practice, the greater the rate of return. I believe this compresses/shortens the posited theory of 10,000 hours in totality being required for mastery even though evidence proves to the contrary. My own stats at this time?

Total playtime: 6384 hours 26 minutes

337 consecutive days of practice

3396 of 4780 tracks at 100%+ mastery

99.87% overall mastery

74188 song playthroughs

94.78% overall accuracy

These are stats that at initial glance appear mind blowing to the average person and are far above statistical norms for the game’s community at this time. Some might argue that I’ve already mastered the guitar, but I’m not even at 70% of 10,000 hours. The only factor? Stacked compression per practice hour.

Today is march 22, 2k26. This whole project that you hold in your hands up to this point is a decade of my life that will never be recovered. This started as just wanting to learn some Def Leppard tracks so I could play my favorite group's songs for myself. I never anticipated that this would be the end result. I've spent years sitting in this chair, surrounded by my instruments, pick in hand, strap across my shoulder, fingers gliding over strings, pushing, pulling, strumming, fingerpicking.

There's a very well known movie series wherein the question is presented "Is it worth it?". The answer given is "Yes, if you're strong enough". There's been three pillars of strength that have been pivotal to me making it this far.

1. I focus on what I've learned not how far I have still to go. I know in my mind at this point that there's still 3 to 4 years left, at my level of saturation that's maddening. When I look back at my old scores and records? That's where I find my solace
2. The record keeping. This has been imperative to my success to date. I don't rely on "feelings", "vibe", "mojo". Show. Me. The. Numbers. I've stated earlier in this document that 1 hour of practice = about .01% across the lifespan of this work thus far. I know it's going to go down the deeper I go into this and that's okay.
3. The knowledge that with everything I've learned? Success is inevitable....for me. With this document? Success is inevitable...for everyone, IF it is applied.

Yeah, a decade of my life is now gone, unrecoverable. If I could go back and change it, would I? Nyah, and not for any moralistic or rewriting imperative...but just because it ain't rock'n'roll to do things like that. I’m seeing this through to the bitter end of 10,000 hours and that...IS rock’n’roll.

Odds are that someone reading this will assume I’m claiming to be the first person to ever reach ten thousand hours. That is the farthest thing from the truth.

For decades, companies that host online games have tracked player statistics across their titles. One of the most basic metrics they record is total in-game time. We all have franchises we love, sometimes to the point of near-daily play. This is not an indictment of those players; people should spend their time on whatever brings them the most satisfaction.

Because of this, I have every reason to believe that many developers and publishers already know exactly what ten thousand hours looks like — and what twenty or thirty thousand hours look like as well. They’ve seen it at population scale.

What I am doing here is not claiming to be the first person to ever cross that threshold. I'm not even claiming to be the first to document it privately. What I do believe is that I'm the first to make a complete, longitudinal, single-subject dataset publicly available, with the intent of examining what long-arc practice actually looks like over time.

Through my experience in this project, I began noticing a pattern in how skills and knowledge actually take root. Because I kept detailed records, I can give this to you straight — no mysticism, no motivational fluff. Just the pattern as it revealed itself over thousands of hours.

Think of your mind like a computer.

Your **conscious mind** is the laptop. This is where active learning happens — the stuff you're thinking about, struggling with, repeating, correcting. Like any laptop, it can only run so many processes at once.

Your **subconscious** — your muscle memory — is the external hard drive or cloud storage. This is where long-term, automatic skill lives. It's bigger, deeper, and more stable, but the connection between the two is slow. Think USB 2.0, not fiber-optic.

Across every 1,000-hour window, I've seen the same three-phase cycle:

Phase 1 — The First 300 Hours: Conscious Learning

This is hands-on, eyes-open, brain-engaged work. Everything is effortful. Everything is manual. You're loading new files onto the laptop.

Phase 2 — The Second 300 Hours: Transfer Window

This is where the system starts offloading what you learned into long-term storage. And here's the part nobody tells you:

Skills being transferred cannot be accessed with full fidelity.

It's like trying to open a ZIP file or a torrent before it's finished downloading. You *can* do it, but it's slow, glitchy, and unreliable. This is the period where people feel stuck, frustrated, or convinced they're getting worse.

They're not. The system is just busy.

Phase 3 — The Third 300 Hours: Subconscious Integration

The transfer completes. The skill becomes automatic. Movements smooth out. Accuracy stabilizes. Breakthroughs happen.

This is the moment everyone thinks is "overnight improvement." It isn't. It's the end of a long, invisible rewrite process.

There's no shortcut I've found. No hack. No way to speed up the cable.

The process takes the time it takes.

And this — right here — is why so many people quit. Not because they lack talent. Not because they're doing anything wrong. But because they mistake the transfer window for failure.

The skills aren't gone. They're just in transit.

If you stick with it, the wall gives.

At hour marker 6547:06 on May third 2026, I uncovered evidence that supports my "5-7" rule. I was playing alt lead 1 and alt lead 2 of Bohemian Rhapsody by queen. Same song, 2 different arrangements. My initial overall accuracy upon starting this alt/bonus track practice was 94.84%. Alt lead 1 was at 15 playthroughs, alt lead 2 was at 14 playthroughs. I ran both straight through, figuring that the 2 different arrangements would be sufficient differentiation to justify continued practice. Upon pushing alt lead 1 to the then 20 playthrough capped ceiling (5 plays) I moved on to alt lead 2. My accuracy visibly stagnated through the subsequent playthrough sufficient to drop .01% (xbox one and xbox live tracked and monitored) to 94.83%. The arrangement doesn't matter. It's the song itself that cannot be repeated more than 5 to 7 times subesequently.

At hour marker 6558 on may 7th 2026 I was doing work on another project similar to this regarding drums. (Death Adder Drummer to be released upon completion of 10,000 hrs and 1 minute of drumming practice) While doing quarter notes at 80 bpm on snare? I started to drift on the 6th set 8th exercise. I had earlier been under the impression that 24 hours was the minimum needed to recover after practicing a piece 5 to 7 times. I have found that the actual window is between 45 minutes to an hour to re-enter the piece with a clean slate. My practice window with snare right now is set to 24 minutes, after which I do an hour and 15 minutes in the room time (60 minutes behind the strings time) of either lead, rhythm, or bass. I then upon completion do a second set of drum practice or a third. Upon re-entering the drums after an hour? There's no drift until that same 6th set. So, if you're working on a riff or a song and you start noticing yourself making mistakes? Stop working on it the moment you notice cognitive decline, give yourself 45 to 60 minutes, then circle back.

The objective is to keep your reps CLEAN. Pushing for "Just one more run" is exactly what lets mistakes start to creep in. When these mistakes start entering? These become habit and must be broken again. This is regression. When you're grinding and trying to force a riff or a song or a solo to perfection? The exact opposite is occurring.

June 18, 2026

Today I hit 2/3 completion to 10,000 hours.

Total playtime 6667:43

441 consecutive days of practice. Record is 590

3495 of 4780 tracks @ 100%+

path breakdown lead 47% rhythm 32% bass 20%

overall mastery 100.53%

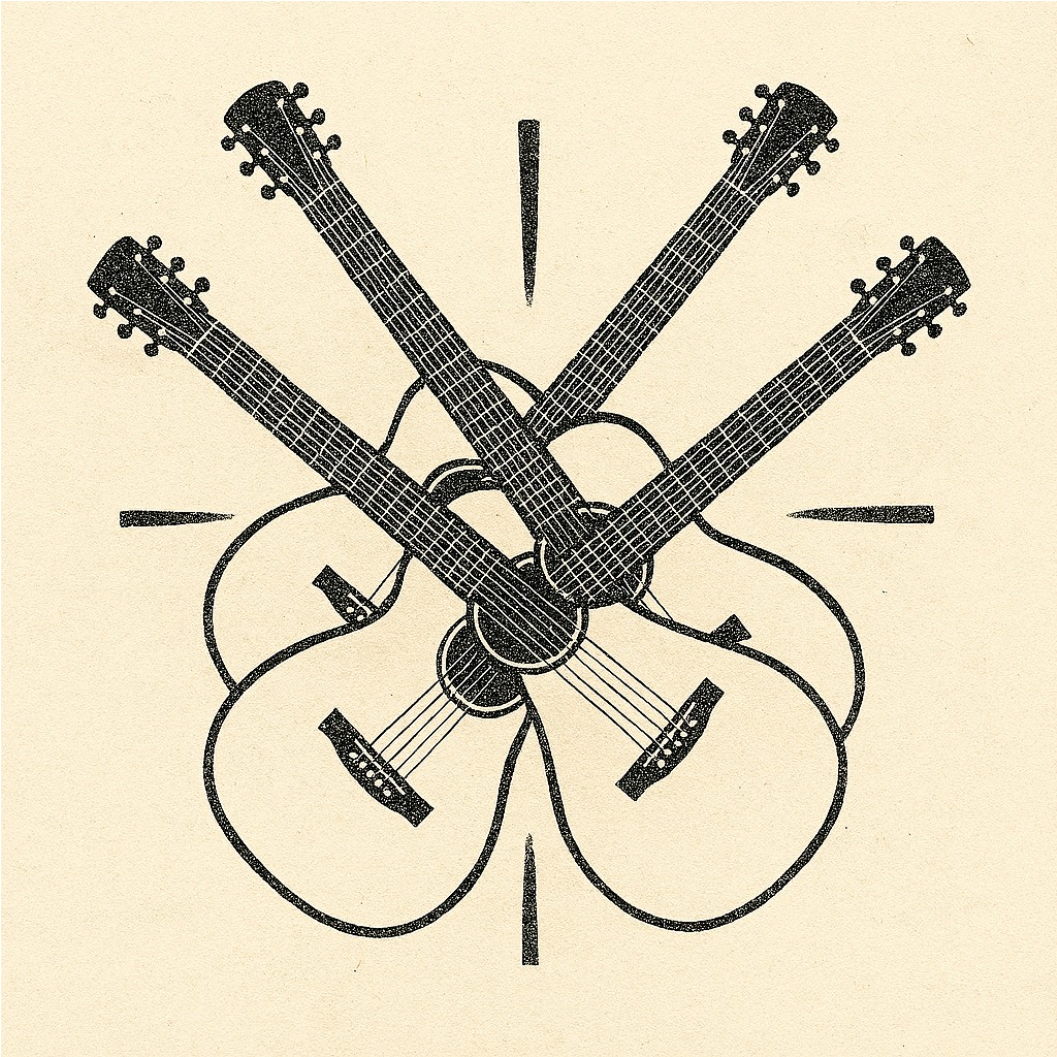
78188 song playthroughs

overall accuracy 94.89%

Never thought I’d make it this far. Still got a long way to go. I’m 333 hours away from 7k hours. More to come later.

“Now, this here’s what we call’s a ‘bibliography’, shows what he read and how many times he bought the same materials pretty much. Don’t very much matter how many books you buy when it’s all under the same field you see. The only thing that ever changes book to book? Is the tone the author’s speakin’ in and the order in which the stuff’s presented. Oh there’s one or two that he liked more and a few books that go into very specific things, but how many books you really need on music theory when you don’t even know the strings under your fingers? You ever wonder how many scales are actually used ninety percent of the time? About six. Finger exercises? What you think you’re doing when you’re playing, practicing scales and chords? Working your fingers out. Not every book was garbage, it just took Ol’ Matthew a while to find his footin’. Happens to the best...and the worst of us. How big is your library huh? How many books of learnin’ you got?”

~C.R. D’aemon



My book library

$42.00 Gladwell, Malcolm. *Outliers: The Story of Success*. New York: Little, Brown and Company, 2008.

$14.99 Guitar Head. Guitar Scales Workshop: 3 in 1—How to Solo Like a Guitar God Even If You Don't Know Where to Start + A Simple Way to Create Your Very First Solo. Independently published, 2019.

$14.99 Pratt, Simon. The Guitar Finger-Gym: Build Stamina, Coordination and Dexterity on the Guitar. Fundamental Changes, 2016.

$19.99 Alexander, Joseph. Fingerstyle Blues Guitar: Master Acoustic Blues Guitar Fingerpicking and Soloing. Fundamental Changes, 2015.

$14.99 Williams, Chas. The Nashville Number System. Chas Williams, 2023

$21.20 Alexander, Joseph. The Complete Guide to Playing Blues Guitar: Rhythm Guitar. 2nd ed. Fundamental Changes, 2014.

$19.99 Alexander, Joseph. The Complete Guide to Playing Blues Guitar: Melodic Phrasing. 2nd ed. Fundamental Changes, 2014.

$19.99 Alexander, Joseph. The Complete Guide to Playing Blues Guitar: Soloing. 2nd ed. Fundamental Changes, 2014.

$28.00 Goodrick, Mick. The Advancing Guitarist. Hal Leonard, 1987.

$44.99 Leavitt, William. A Modern Method for Guitar: Volumes 1, 2, 3 Complete. Berklee Press, 2020.

$19.99 Clay, Levi, and Joseph Alexander. Delta Blues Slide Guitar: A Complete Guide to Authentic Acoustic Blues Slide Guitar. Fundamental Changes, 2018.

$12.99 Rivera, Miggs. The Percussive Acoustic Guitar Method: Volume I. Independently published, 2018.

$12.99 Rivera, Miggs. The Percussive Acoustic Guitar Method: Volume II. Independently published, 2021.

$14.99 Guitar Head. Guitar Chords Bible: Instant Access to 1053 Chords with Chord Functions and Progressions. Independently published, 2020.

$26.99 Perlak, Kim, ed. Berklee Guitar Theory. Berklee Press, 2023.

$18.98 Shipway, James. No Bull Music Theory for Guitarists: Master the Essential Knowledge All Guitarists Need to Know. Headstock Books, 2019.

$19.99 Shipway, James. Music Theory for Guitarists: Volume 2. Headstock Books, n.d.

$19.99 Shipway, James. Music Theory for Guitarists: Volume 3. Headstock Books, n.d.

$16.99 Fox, Dan. Alfred's Teach Yourself to Read Music for Guitar: Practical Music Reading for All Guitarists! Alfred Publishing, 2006.

$12.99 MacKay, Steve. Simply Guitar. Hinkler Books, 2014.

$14.99 Kaye, Hereward. Guitar Chords: A Fretboard Sticker Book. Thunder Bay Press, 2017.

$24.00 Marcus, Gary. Guitar Zero: The New Musician and the Science of Learning. Penguin Books, 2012.

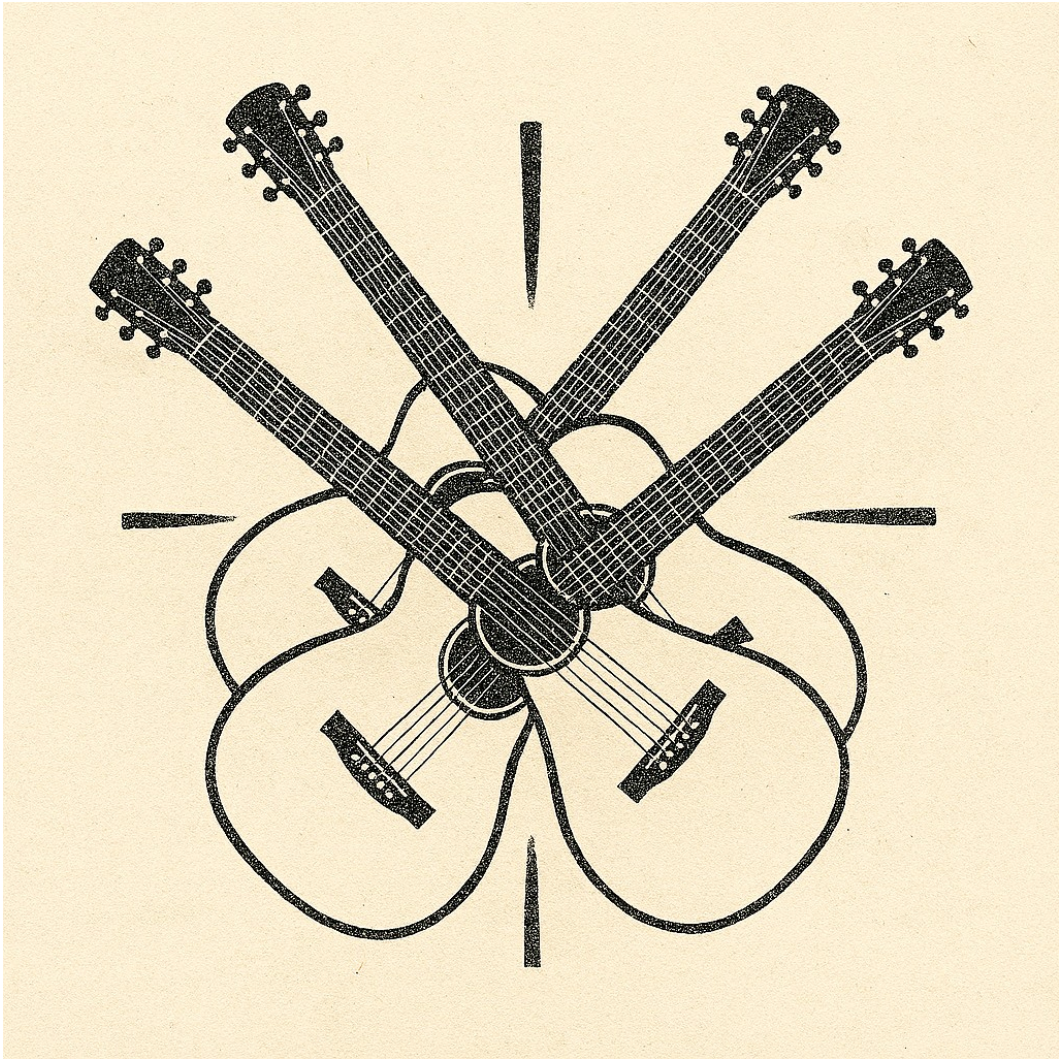
$35.00 Freeth, Nick, and Charles Alexander. The Guitar. Running Press, 2002.

$17.99 Vai, Steve. *Guitar World Presents Steve Vai's Guitar Workout*. Milwaukee: Hal Leonard, 2013.

Grand total $268.86

“Oh of course he’s got to show off his stuff. No man needs more than one guitar, a small parlour will do the job. Works for me just fine, laughable what a man spends...what are you doing? Let me see that, YOU ARE NOT SHOPPING RIGHT NOW! Yes you is. Don’t….no, that’s not how this works. Just one guitar is all you...Don’t you look at me in that tone of voice, you can’t even play the one you got! No...close the window. Close it. I said CLOSE IT. No, minimized is not closed. Stop it. Wishlist is the exact same thing as a cart. I don’t want to hear it. Wishlist is a premediated shopping cart. Yes, it is. It’s a cart with plausible deniability’s what it is. Matthew does that all the time. Yes it’s the same thing as a cart. Yes it is. No you are never just watching it, you’re fixing to buy it. Stop it...Y’all need therapy or an intervention or Jesus or something. I swear.”

~C.R. D’aemon



Guitar Collection

Ibanez

$209.99 Gio: 5y220400761

$279.99 Gio: gs190403432

$229.99 Gio: 5n210701297

$209.99 Gio Mikro: 5a230700376

$219.99 Gio Mikro bass: 140316057

Jackson

$419.99 Dinky: cwj2156949

$499.99 Dinky: cwj2046683

Yamaha

$299.99 Pacifica: iki153678

$180.00 - $250.00 RBX:1z18035

Fender

$599.00 Jaguar: mz9579672

$400.00 Telecaster: Made in mexico, replacement neck, serial unknown

$500.00 CD 140 SCE: iwa1949347

$239.99 FA 135CE: cff1524313

$399.99 CD60 SCE 12: ips170901839

Squier

$499.00 Jazzmaster: icsa21030516

$189.00 Bullet Mustang: crnl21000274

$199.00 Affinity Telecaster: icns12108535

$260.00 5 string jazz bass: cy141103642

$180.00 Affinity Stratocaster: IC070540761

$250.00 Bullet Stratocaster: ics13008752

$400.00 Classic Vibe 50’s stratocaster: cgs1125327

Kadence

$119.00 Acoustica: ao6eq

$119.00 Acoustica: ao5eq

$160.00 Slowhand: nadsh03hq

$160.00 Slowhand: kadsh04eq

Dean

$249.00 MLX: o09120959

B.C. Rich

$300.00 Warlock: h01082769

Gretsch

$499.00 Streamliner g2655: is181204951

Oscar Schmidt by washburn

$350.00 oe40n: sj04063333

Ashthorpe

$169.00 D90: 2010-3214

$112.00 “S” style: no s/n

Glarry

$90.00 “T” style thinline: no s/n

$100.00 “P” bass style: no s/n

$100.00 “J” bass style: no s/n

$69.99 Burning Fire: no s/n

$89.99 Rg style: no s/n

$100.00 4 string acoustic bass: no s/n

$113.00 Ovation style: no s/n

KGD

$399.00 Relic “T” style: krs351015

$135.00 Relic Explorer style: krs3s1065

Schecter

$500.00 c6 elite: 1c17002041

$640.00 omen extreme: iw17121838

First act

$179.00 222: 22029d17084

Epiphone

$199.00 SG special ve: s108032195

$499.00 SG: 21011522466

$150.00 Les Paul Junior: 1006238155

$300.00 Les Paul Special 2: 2105131266

$550.00 Les Paul Standard: ee080309114

$600.00 Dot: 20081524052

$700.00 Thunderbird goth: uco7050451

Leo Jaymz

$119.00 each Double cut deluxe x2: no s/n’s

$120.00 each Single cut deluxe x2: no s/n’s

Grote

$199.00 Goldtop “LP” style: gs2021190688

$179.00 Cherry burst “LP” style: no s/n

$179.00 Tobacco burst “LP” style: no s/n

$269.00 335 style: gs2021190699

Fojill

$249.00 Relic “LP” style: no s/n

$199.00 Relic “S” style: no s/n

Gibson

$1500.00 Les Paul Studio Jem Amethyst: 91137440

$4500.00 es335: 00170428

Kit built

$200.00 Firebird copy: no s/n

Hard Luck Kings

$349.00 Spider: 15-1810014

$300.00 Bossman 26-007

Zenison

$200.00 Destroyer copy: no s/n

$200.00 Flying v copy: no s/n

Sterling by music man

$329.00 Sub series 4: b118561

Rogue

$179.00 lx200b: no s/n

Auriga

$90.00 “S” style copy: yg2103096

Lyxpro

$89.00 “S” style copy: no s/n

IYV (Inyen Vina)

$199.00 prs semi hollow copy: 122030015

$170.00 prs style solid body (black):123010002

$150.00 prs style solid body (burst): 124100818

$180.00 Rickenbacker style (cherry): no s/n

$170.00 Mosrite style w/bigsby: 124112332

$161.19 LP double cut style tv yellow:I24090429

PRS

$550.00 SE standard: ctie19686

Pyle

$175.00 Spider cone resonator: no s/n

Vevor

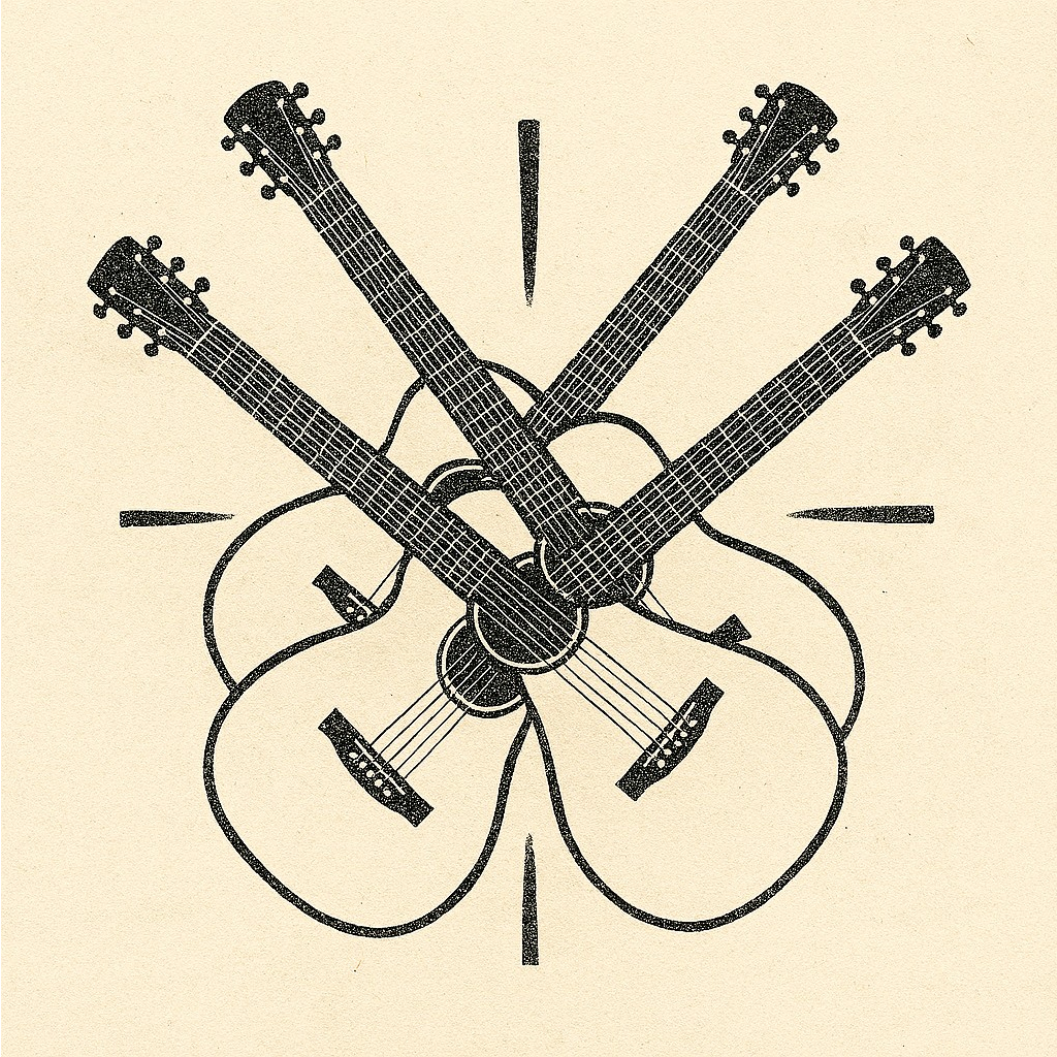
$49.99 nylon string classical: no s/n

Aklot

$130.00 nylon string cutaway dreadnought: no s/n

“Of course he had to go to a variety of amplifiers, that’s what a soundhole is for. If you ain’t performing? What’s it matter? Most you need is a pignose amplifier, most of y’all ain’t even playing to nobody but friends and family...are you takin’ notes AGAIN? Why? Ain’t nothin’ there. Man’s got THREE Line 6 amps, who you talkin’ to on the phone? Gimme that. Give it, give it, give it. Hello? Who’s this? You don’t ask me who I am, I’m askin’ you. Uh huh...Oh it’s on sale? What’s in the cart? Oh it’s not in the cart, it’s in the watchlist? You mean the premeditated purchase pile. 4 x 12 cab? 250 watt head? Uh huh...Bye. What are you thinking? You’re playing in a 12 square foot room! You’re gonna explode yourself if you put that at 2. Your HOA is gonna put your stuff in a dumpster because you’ve exploded every window on the block! I’m gonna go talk to my studio guy up in Windsor, ontario...He’ll at least laugh at the three Line 6 amps right along with me. We’ll have a good old knee slappin time. Someone that knows quality, unlike the both of you.”

~C.R. D’aemon



Amplifiers

$1259.99 Fender hot rod deville

$179.00 Fender bronco

$100.00 Fender mustang 1

$400.00 Fender frontman 212r (Mojotone anthem speakers)

$700.00 Marshall origin 50

$100.00 Crate ca125d

$60.00 Glenn burton 10 watt

$150.00 Boss katana mk1

$150.00 line 6 lowdown 150 (celestion pulse speaker)

$150.00 Line 6 spider 2 150

$120.00 Line 6 spider 5 60

$800.00 Vox ac15 (white tolex, celestion creamback speaker)

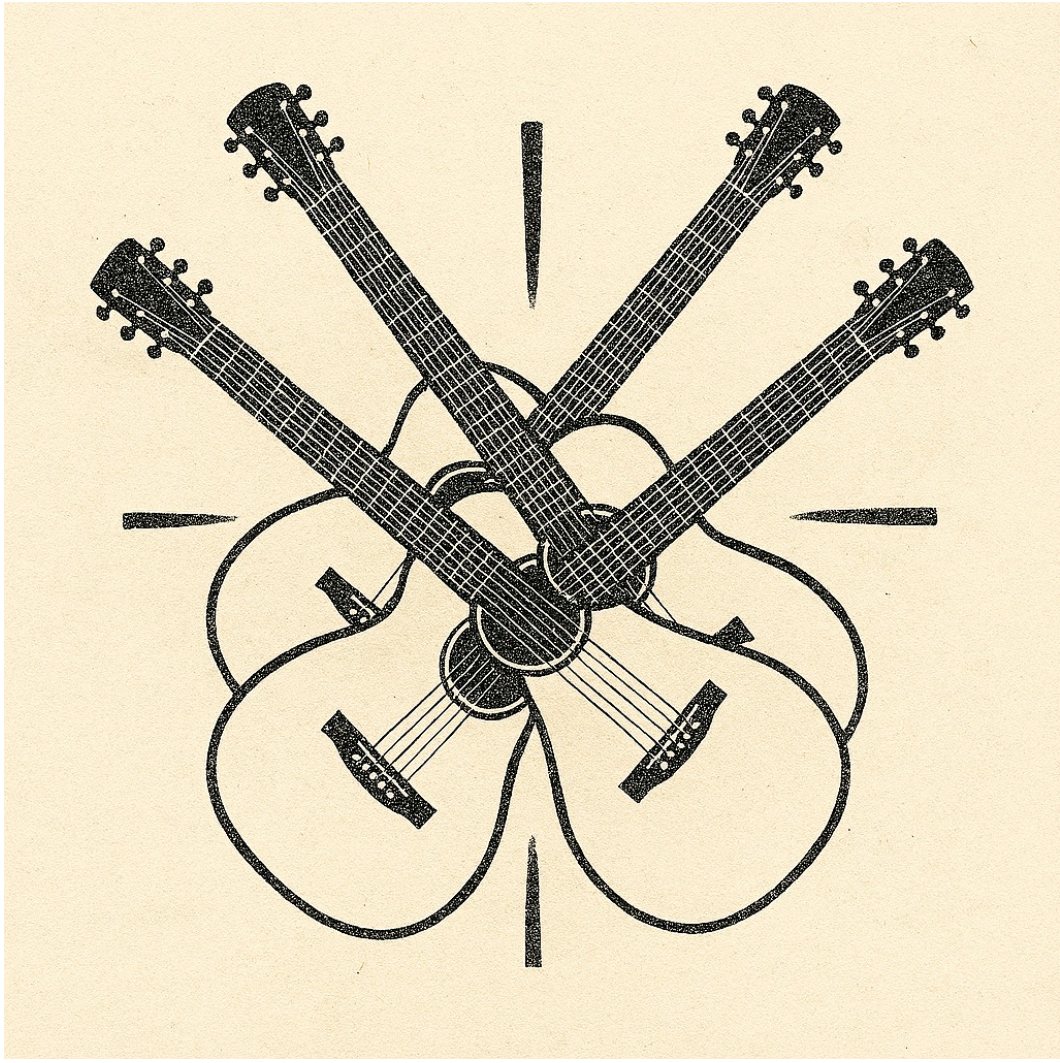
(included with guitar) Glarry 15 watt amp

Epiphone studio 15c $44.00

$4,268.99

“Yup, this is the biggest devourer of your practice. This is where “tone chasin’” was born. Knobs, switches, levers, anything to keep your fingers off of those strings….Pay attention! Tryin’ to tell you something here. You look at Ol Matthew here, wahs, distortions, overdrive...Good, you’re takin’ notes. Multiples of each, he calls it seasonin’ and spice...He might as well set his money on...ARE YOU SHOPPING AGAIN?!? Excuse me, my phone’s ringing….Hello? Yes, this is he. Oh, hi boss, it’s you. No, they ain’t signed yet. I’m tryin’...Yes sir, I know the deadline’s around the corner. Yessir, yessir, uh-huh. No not meanin’ no disrespect, but when’s the last time you...No, I don’t want to see if that’s physically possible. No sir, that won’t be necessary. I’m on it. You have a lovely day too sir. My god that guy’s an asshole...Really? You went vintage pedals? You spent 10,000 dollars on a pedal? What is the matter with you? Oh an ‘investment’ uh-huh I got beachfront property in central Arizona for sale. Are you done building shrines to bad decisions and wasted bucks yet? So, here’s a pen, just there in your hand, the tip goes on the dotted line, you know you want to.”

~C.R. D’aemon



Pedals and effects units

Line 6

$150.00 fbv shortboard x2

$38.90 Behringer Hellbabe

$100.00 Dunlop Crybaby Wah

$80.00 Proco rat

$111.70 Ehx cockfight

$90.90 Ehx big muff pi

$129.99 Dunlop fuzzface (small, blue)

$39.99 Joyo vintage overdrive

$149.99 Boss Fuzz

$109.99 Boss Blues Driver

$49.99 Boss sd1

$199.00 Angry Charlie v3

$49.99 Boss ds1

$49.99 Blackstar LT metal

$39.99 Donner Morpher

$129.99 Mxr double double overdrive

$119.00 Warm audio ODD

$169.00 Ibanez ts9

$77.10 Ehx crayon

$119.99 Boss metal zone

$99.99 MXR distortion plus

$39.99 Joyo american

$39.99 Joyo british

$39.99 Joyo oxford

$39.99 Joyo california

$39.99 Joyo actone

$39.99 Joyo splinter

$49.99 Demon fx klon copy

$49.99 Demon fx king of drive

$146.99 Fender pugilist

$249.99 Fender santa ana

$56.90 Behringer fuzz bender

$25.90 Behringer chromatic tuner

$20.90 Behringer vintage overdrive

$27.90 Behringer super fuzz

$32.90 Behringer digital multi fx

$32.90 Behringer digital reverb

$23.90 Behringer vintage delay

$22.90 Behringer eq pedal

$27.90 Behringer noise gate

$27.90 Behringer heavy distortion

$130.00 Morley wah

$25.00 Donner blues driver

$80.00 EHX Memory Boy

$20.00 Donner yellow fall

$49.99 Vox v835

$100.00 boss dd3

$85.00 fender mirror image

$80.00 EHX Canyon micro

$85.00 MXR Carbon Copy

$32.00 Donner Dynamic Wah

$45.00 Donner Verb square

$199.00 Line 6 dl4 mk1

$110.00 Fender Marine reverb

$97.00 tc electronic hall of fame reverb

$75.00 EHX holy grail

$50.00 Marshall reflector

$100.00 boss rv6

$25.00 joyo 6 band eq x2

$30.00 Joyo flanger

Summation

Well, it’s been a hell of a ride now hasn’t it? For those that only know the myth? Robert Johnson went to the crossroads, laid down his guitar and the devil appeared. He retuned Robert’s guitar, handed it back to him and with that he sold his soul for the skill to play. Obviously according to the tale, the Hell hounds were unleashed upon him with his life being the price. It’s a colorful tale to be sure, but history tells a different tale in actuality.

History hints at Robert Johnson going back to his hometown of Hazelhurst, Mississippi. He went under the tutelage of Ike Zimmerman an Alabama bluesman. It’s believed that he studied for 2 years under him. The reported location was a graveyard with two above ground tombs so they could sit across from each other and Robert could learn in peace. I average 3.6 hours of practice per day. Robert was under the instruction of what would culturally be considered that era’s Edward Van Halen, Jimi Hendrix, George Lynch, or Synyster Gates (insert whomever you hold in high esteem here). I know through my experience that 4.5 hours per day is PLAUSIBLE so long as it’s “in the room” time, and not “behind the strings” time.

I didn’t sell my soul to get where I am with my skillset. Does it feel like it? Yeah, it does. I’ve lost contact with friends, with family members, lost time with my family, and pets. So, by my rough estimate? In 2 years under those conditons? Robert could have easily acquired around 3500 hours of practice under a premiere instructor. The only reason that Robert Johnson is so mythic? Is because nobody tried to reconstruct his educational syllabus. They just rebuilt the end product.

3504:06 | 88.73%

That’s where I was at 3500 hours. Now, the high end?

4002:52 | 92.29%

Sweep picking, two handed tapping, 220 beats per minute? These were unheard of for his time. I tell you from lived experience that this would have been completely plausible. Two years is more than enough time with a world class instructor (bear in mind that Robert did have prior “noodling” experience) in a pre-internet, pre television, pre-radio world with as slow as the world moved back then in his era? He would very easily have been seen by peers, by fans as an absolute force of nature. He had a total of 28 songs. The lion’s share of them being at or under three minutes of duration. I’ve been cramming 4780 tracks. He had 28.

The crossroads tale was foundational for this journey. Why? Partially to respect to those that came before me. Partially to pass it down to the next generation. This

work on just the data alone was FAR too dry for the normal person to read and take in. So, the legend is now passed down yet again.

I have probably spent more hours in that damned practice room strumming, flat picking, finger picking, slapping, popping, two handed tapping, arpeggiating, and sweep picking than I ever care to remember by this point. 10,000 hours, 100%+ mastery, 120k + song playthroughs. If all you see is me playing a videogame? That's a "you" problem. I needed a neutral metric, an independent, unmanipulatable referee. If you're able to present a better logged metric that hasn't been modified, is incapable of prejudice, doesn't suffer hearing loss? Then I'll concede. But that's ONLY if all you see is a video game.

Here's the catch:

10,000 LOGGED hours, no gaps

100%+ overall mastery (machine and server verified

80%+ of 4780 tracks at 100% or higher

120,000 song playthroughs

An hour and a half concert is about 18 songs. That puts me at over 6,000 concerts I've performed in that room. That's a concert and an opening act every day for 12 years, no days off, no breaks. Think it over.

B.B. King did 15000 concerts.

Concerts as of Aug 6, 2022

Blue oyster cult 4440

Cheap trick 3914

Alice Cooper 3225

ZZ Top 3176

Kiss 2830

Bruce Springsteen 2795

Iron Maiden 2498

Judas Priest 2497

Aerosmith 2454

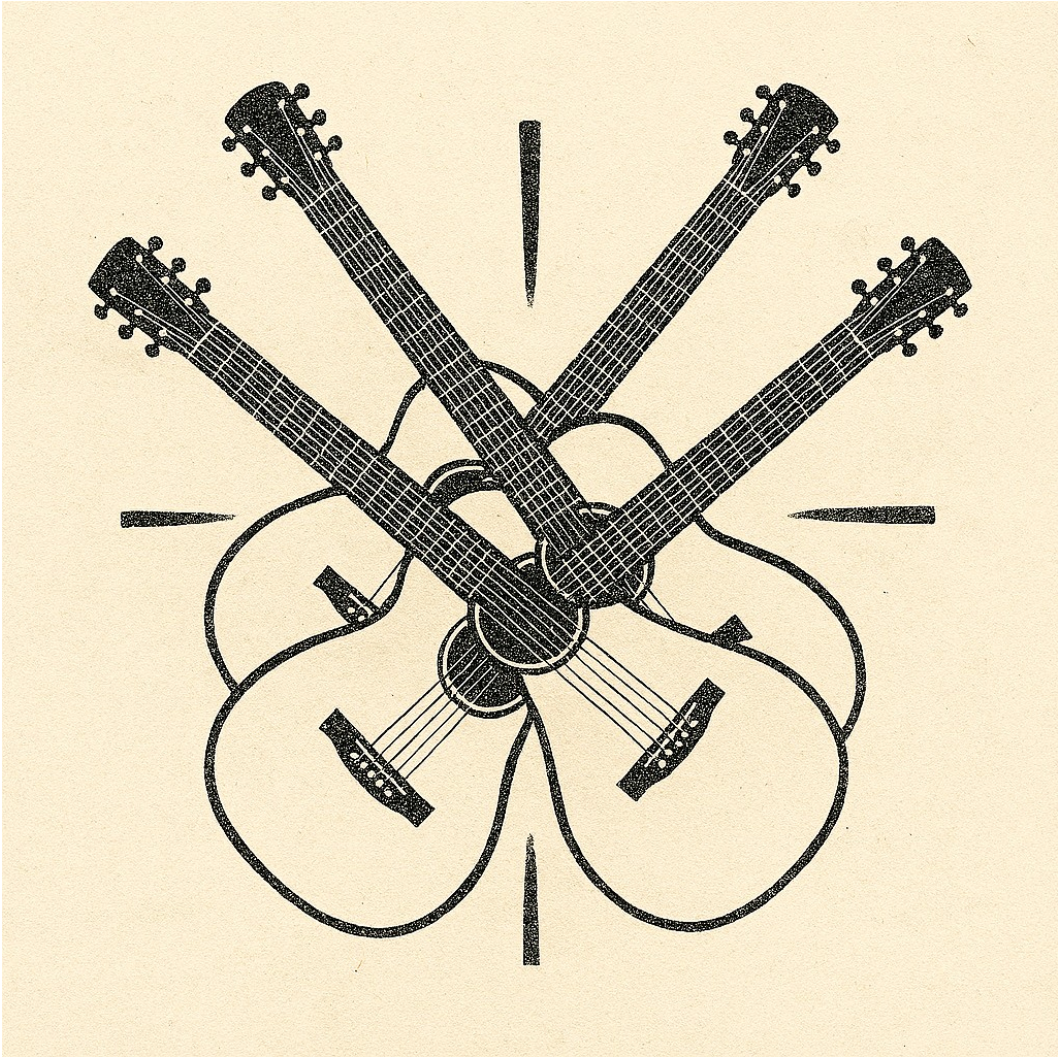
Megadeth 2436

Shall I continue?

So far as that public interpretation of the 10,000 hour rule? I can, without doubt, hesitation or pause state that it is absolutely, undeniably, complete….

“That’ll be more than sufficient Mr. Lee, you’ve done made your point and there’s been more than enough jaw waggin’ out of you. You are hereby released from your contract! Now, go on. Git! Vamoose! Get your backside movin’! As for you, you’re comin’ wit me. You done seen all you need seein’ to make your own damn mind up. Don’t you go worryin’ your head now. You’re safe..for the time bein’. You and me? We’s gonna have a sit down type of chat. We got business to tend to and time’s a-runnin out….too many damn people flappin’ their yap on this particular topic without doin’ it they damn selves. Givn’ me gut rot and makin’ my belly ache”

~C.R. D’aemon





“Right this way, I’m waiting..”



“Sign.”



“Your.”



“NAME.”


CONTRACT

Lender: X Claudius Robinette D’aemon

Debtor: X……

Witness: X Matthew Lee

THE RECKONING

Well now… Look at you. You made it all the way to the end.

Most don’t. Most get lost somewhere back in the hours, or the numbers, or the truth of what this road really costs. But you kept turning pages. You kept watching. You kept tallying the price.

I can see it on you.

Some of you signed your name the moment you saw that dotted line. Couldn’t help yourselves. That’s alright. Impulse has its own kind of honesty.

Some of you waited. Read every chapter. Measured the weight before you put your mark down. That’s a different kind of truth.

And a few of you… left the line empty.

I noticed that too.

Don’t worry — I’m not here to judge any of you. Judgment was never part of the deal. I told you at the start: I don’t care which way you choose.

But I do keep track.

The eyes flare a little brighter at the ones who signed early. The smoke curls different around the ones who waited. And the shadows lean in close to the ones who walked the whole road without ever touching pen to paper.

And now that you’ve seen the cost for yourself… now that you know exactly what this road demands…

You signing or not?

Because I’m standing right here in front of you, and I’m doing my level best to stay patient…

…but I don’t hold still forever.

You’ve seen what the last traveler paid. You’ve seen what this kind of devotion does to a life.

So this is where I step back.

The last page is yours. Your choice. Your road.

Just remember: Whatever you wrote — or didn’t write — back at the start… the road remembers too.

Last chance son, what’s it gonna be?

The Serpentine Library

Soundhole Sidewinder (Guitar and bass)

Vocal Viper (Lead vocals)

Death Adder Drummer (Drums)

Python Pianist (Piano/keyboard)